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«Transformation of Discourse of the Chinese Communist Party Representatives on Arctic Region: from 2013 to 2024»

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Table of contents

Abstract 5

Introduction 6

Relevance 6

Literature review 8

Research structure 15

Chapter 1 Methodological, theoretical and historical framework of the study 16

1.1. Methodology 16

1.1.2. Potential shortcomings, limitations and expected outcomes 18

1.2. Theoretical framework 19

1.3. Historical context of the Chinese involvement in Arctic affairs 21

1.4. Relations between China and Arctic states 25

1.4.1. US-China relations in the Arctic region 25

1.4.2. Russia-China relations in the Arctic region 26

1.4.3. China-Finland relations on the Arctic region 28

1.4.4. Sino-Danish relations in the Arctic 29

1.4.5. Sino-Icelandic relations in the Arctic 31

1.4.6. Sino-Swedish relations in the Arctic 32

1.4.7. Sino-Norwegian relations in the Arctic 33

1.4.8. China-Canada relations in the Arctic 34

1.5. Chapter conclusion 35

Chapter 2 The Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs within the period of 2013-2017 36

Introduction 36

2.1. Compliance with previous direction of the discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs 36

2.1.1. China as a good party to international treaties and organizations 37

2.1.2. China as a supporter of preserving the sovereignty and interests of Arctic states 38

2.1.3. China as a Near-Arctic state 39

2.2. Discourse on Arctic affairs after the start of presidency of Xi Jinping 40

2.2.1. China as a responsible great power (“负责任大国”) 43

2.2.2. China as an Arctic stakeholder 45

2.2.3. Respect, collaboration and win-win cooperation (“尊重、合作与共赢”) 45

2.2.4. Chinese cooperation within the Arctic region 47

2.3. Community of Common Destiny for Mankind 48

2.4. Environmental protection and climate change 50

2.5. Chapter conclusion 51

Chapter 3 The Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs within the period of 2018-2024 53

Introduction 53

3.1. Compliance with direction of the discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs before 2013 53

3.1.1. China as a good party to international treaties and organizations 53

3.1.2. China as a supporter of preserving the sovereignty and interests of Arctic states 54

3.1.3. China as a Near-Arctic state 55

3.2. Chinese White Paper on the Arctic 55

3.3. The Belt and Road initiative 57

3.3.1. China-Russia cooperation 58

3.3.2. Polar Silk Road 59

3.4. Perception of Arctic policies by president Xi administration 60

3.4.1. Principles of ‘not to go overboard and not to be 63

absent'('不越位、不缺位')

3.4.2. Chinese position on Arctic governance **65**

3.5. The issue of securitization within Arctic discourse **66**

3.6. Chapter conclusion **67**

Conclusion **69**

Limitations of the study **72**

Prospects for further research **72**

Reference list **74**

Abstract

The role of People's Republic of China (PRC) in Arctic affairs is an important part of the discourse of Chinese Communist Party (CCP) representatives. This study is based on the theory of constructivism which allows to analyze Chinese identity in the Arctic and its ambitions in the region, focusing on the period of 2013-2024. This work studies continuity and change in the Arctic discourse of the CCP representatives using discourse analysis and policy analysis to provide a comprehensive view on Chinese Arctic policies and discourse within the given period. This study identifies main directions of Chinese discourse on the Arctics and analyses their transformation within the official discourse, as well as studies whether previously existing features of CCP representatives' discourse on Arctic affairs remained and transformed during the period of 2013-2024.

Keywords: China, Arctic region, diplomatic rhetoric, discourse analysis, Belt and Road Initiative, Community of Common Destiny for Mankind.

Introduction

Relevance

The discourse of China on Arctic affairs and its behavior in the international system is relevant due to the increasing power of China and its ambitions to increase its influence and the level of participation in international issues. As the PRC is still developing at a rapid pace, there is a necessity for China to be actively engaged in the decision-making process within the Arctic region. Through participation in Arctic affairs China becomes able to pursue its interests in different dimensions, such as the interest to increase its reputation by obtaining the legal status to conduct its policies in the region in order to get international recognition of being an Arctic player. According to Kobzeva (2017)the economic interests are also important for China as the Arctic provides it with the opportunity to use the Northern Sea Route to ensure the safety and quick navigation for its freight transportation. Moreover, Chinese companies actively participate in projects of Arctic states, cooperating with local enterprises providing investments and improving infrastructure to ameliorate resource extraction and scientific development. Another important point is the political dimension of Chinese involvement in the Arctic region, as China elaborates a strategy of cooperation with Arctic states to increase its presence as well as to affect the position of other states. As Zuenko (2024) states, together with Russia China aims to prevent the United States from strengthening in the region, which would benefit the Chinese position not only in the Arctic but also on the international arena.

Moreover, China is a participant of organisations and forums dedicated to the topic of the Arctic. Thus, China is an observer in the Arctic council, a member of the International Arctic Science Committee. Also, China holds trilateral dialogue on the Arctic together with Japan and South Korea in order to get support and strengthen its positions in the Arctic. Therefore, China aims to gradually increase its presence and power in decision-making in Arctics in order to obtain its goals within and outside the region.

To analyze the process of discourse transformation on the Arctic within Chinese officials, this work considers statements, speeches and interviews of Chinese policymakers published by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of China, the government of China and Xinhua News agency. The timeframe of the research is from 2013 to 2024 which is chosen to evaluate the cooperation of China with third states on Arctic affairs in recent years as well to trace the continuity of Arctic policies of since the beginning Xi Jinping presidency, which lead to increased participation in Arctic affairs due to the promotion of BRI Initiative as well as due to the increased pace of Chinese economic development to the implementation of policies written in white paper on Arctic policy of China in 2018.

The goal of the research is to trace the change and continuity of Chinese discourse on Arctic issues.

The tasks of the research are:

1) To study the historical context of Chinese involvement in Arctic affairs before the given framework of 2013.

2) To analyze dimensions of Chinese interest in Arctics.

3) To identify main factors, which shape Chinese discourse on policies in the Arctic region within 2013-2024.

The object of the research is the discourse within the representatives of Chinese Communist Party during 2013-2024. The subject of the research is the transformation of the discourse within a given period.

Literature review

The issue of Chinese involvement in Arctic affairs and the role of Chinese policymakers in shaping direction of Chinese policies in the Arctic region were studied in various manners.

Thus, Western scholars put main emphasis on the security dimension of Chinese involvement in the Arctic. According to Lackenbauer & Manicom (2013) and Kienko (2019), Western analysts perceive Chinese Arctic policies as a threat to the existing order in the region, where China together with other non-Arctic states claims that the Arctic region is a common area, where all representatives of international community have shared interests, thus, Arctic states could not conduct global Arctic policies independently from international community. However, Lackenbauer & Manicom (2013) claim that nowadays the PRC does not pursue aggressive policy in the Arctic and does not aim to violate international law.

Vylegzhanin & Kienko (2021) also claim that there is no ground to consider Chinese participation in the Arctic as a threat to the existing order as China does not aim to increase its military presence in the region and does not make attempts to split the Arctic Council. Nevertheless, the analysis of speeches of Chinese policymakers provided in the article supports the idea that China is not content with the role of Ilulissat declaration of 2008 which promotes the vision of Arctic states towards further policy-making. Thus, in 2018 China started to hold a trilateral dialogue with Japan and South Korea on Arctic affairs to coordinate their efforts by signing treaties and making financial contributions to the research and environmental projects within the dialogue. Kobzeva (2017) pointed out that all 3 states are observers in the Arctic Council, which have rights to participate in working groups of the Arctic council. Hence, China aims to broaden the scope of possible partners in the region and attract a larger number of non-Arctic states to a greater level of involvement in regional affairs. Moreover, Suslov & Kashin (2022) highlighted that the increasing presence of China in the Arctic region is the result of the growing influence of China in the international system, which shapes the

necessity for the PRC to be present in the region, whereas for China, its presence in other regions such as the Middle East or Africa could be of greater importance.

There is also a discourse on the consistency of Chinese policies in the Arctic. Kienko (2019) claims that modern Chinese legal policies are in line with the basis of Chinese strategy of “peaceful rise”, which was proclaimed in 2012 and aimed to turn China into a great maritime state.

Galimullin et. al (2024) also states that after president Xi came to power, China started to conduct consistent Arctic policy, aimed to make China more involved in Arctic affairs, such as securitization of climate protection discourse. Authors also highlight that these policies are aligned with Chinese strategy of the usage of discourse in transformation of the international system.

The role of white paper on the Arctic, which was published by the Chinese government in 2018 was also discussed within the topic. According to Kuang & Ou (2019), the white paper provided guidelines for 5 major direction of Chinese Arctic policies, which implied non-stop research of Arctic region; environmental protection and monitoring; resource extraction on a basis of international law, which implied creation of Ice silk road, which would allow China to be actively engaged in environmental affairs as well as to promote Arctic tourism. Another direction denotes active participation in Arctic governance, where the Chinese government controls all the actions taken by Chinese individuals and entrepreneurs and takes part in international decision-making as well. The last direction proclaimed by the authors is promotion of peace and stability in the region which is required for its development.

In Chinese discourse exist several works on the emergence and rising popularity of Chinese studies of policies made by the PRC government on Arctic affairs. According to Xu & Wang (2021) there exist 3 ways of Chinese studies. The first wave started in 2007 after Russian scientists put the Russian flag on the seabed beneath the North Pole. The Chinese media extensively covered the event, and thus, Chinese academics started writing about the sovereignty of Arctic Ocean, the role of international law in the Arctic, geopolitical rivalry and international

cooperation. The second wave which lasted from 2013 to 2017 China focused on implementing policies, which would increase the level of legitimacy of Chinese actions in the Arctic. The third wave is characterized by the publication of White paper on the Arctic, and researchers were concerned about its role and further development. Moreover, the authors mentioned that there is a common drawback of modern studies of China in the Arctic region, which is the lack of theoretical base for the research, especially highlighting the lack of studies in constructivist framework.

Still, other authors have different approaches towards classification of Chinese Arctic studies. Thus, Wang (2017) outlined 3 stages of Chinese humanitarian research on Arctic affairs, where the initial stage lasted from 2007 to 2009 and characterized the early stage, the initial stage lasted from 2010 to 2012 and the stage of development from 2013 to 2016.

In addition, Xu & Wang (2021) highlighted that in the academic discourse there exist only two directions of studies of Chinese policies within the Arctic region. Thus, some scholars aimed to analyze the strategy and possible influence of Chinese Arctic policies based on Chinese scientific and political discourse, whereas other scholars studied Chinese potential to assess the possibility of cooperation between China and other states.

Li & Li (2020) elaborated another division of stages of Chinese research on Arctic issues. Thus, the first stage, during which Chinese scientists started to engage in Arctic discourse and accumulate Chinese materials on the issue, happened from 2004 to 2007. The second stage, which lasted from 2008 to 2011 marked the creation of initial approaches towards Arctic studies, which were mostly dedicated to the role of geopolitics in contemporary international relations or natural sciences. During the third stage of 2012-2015 the number of researchers largely increased and became more concentrated on political affairs. The fourth and final stage provided by the authors lasted from 2016 to 2019 determined the start of the transition towards active involvement in international scientific discourse on the Arctic.

Another important discourse concerns the level of cooperation between Russia and China in the Arctic region. Many scholars suggest that both states aim to increase their profit by cooperating with each other. Strelnikova et.al (2024) implied that due to the isolated position of Russia within the Arctic Council, nowadays Russia aimed to increase the level of cooperation with friendly Non-Arctic states in order to proceed with the development of its Arctic territories. Moreover, according to Strelnikova et.al (2024) the research area is the least problematic and most favourable area of cooperation between two states. Hence, further development of Sino-Russian relations is an important part of Chinese discourse on the Arctic affairs. What is more, Yakovenko (2023) states that, Russia is interested in diversification of its relations with Asian states, which implies that Chinese presence in Arctic is not a threat, but an opportunity for mutual cooperation, not only with China but also with non-Western states, which could be involved in the process of cooperation. However, Galimullin et. al (2024) wrote that although Russia is considered as a traditional partner of China in the Arctic, since February 2022, when the deterioration of relations between Russia and Western states happened, China has to balance between two sides, due to the idea that Western states could start cooperating against China as well. Therefore, for China it is essential to maintain the existing regional system, due to the fact that China has already elaborated strategies of conducting policies within this system.

The issue of Sino-American relations in the Arctic is also widely discussed among scholars. Due to the increasing level of tension between the PRC and the US, the Arctic is considered as a region where both sides strive for increased influence. According to Xie & Xia (2020), China perceives the Arctic as a common region, whereas the US aims to militarize the Arctic region. Despite US claims that they provide more military equipment to the region to contain Russia and China, authors claim that the US aims to increase its military presence in the Arctic in order to incorporate NATO and its member states into the Arctic dialogue to gain more support in Arctic affairs.

Zabella (2019) also noted that promotion of ecological policies in the Arctic region helps China to strengthen its position on climate change by taking the place of the US which in 2017 during the Trump presidency withdrew from the Paris Agreement. Thus, China becomes able to gain more influence and support in the region at the expense of the USA,

The fact that the Arctic region becomes more securitized due to increasing competition between the US, China and Russia also influences further development of the region. As Kopra (2022) stated, the traditional issues of security become more important within the region, due to the clash between Russia and China and growing tension between US and China. Thus, in order to change the balance of power, China has to increase its presence and adopt new Arctic policies.

However, Xu & Wang (2021) claimed that it is the US who creates the narrative on competition between great powers and strategic competition in the Arctic region, as the Trump administration conducts policies aimed to return great power competition to the top of the dominant security paradigm. Thus, China only reacts to the behavior of China, but itself does not have imperialistic ambitions.

The influence of the Ukraine crisis on Arctic affairs is also a part of discourse. According to Yue & Gu (2024) after the beginning of the Ukraine crisis in 2022 the leading role in Arctic affairs is played by the issue of balance between military, security, diplomacy and alliances between states. Moreover, there is a growing interest in economic and technological development of the region, which makes the Arctic more attractive to the international arena. Thus, Yue & Gu (2024) provide a list of recommendations for further Arctic policies of China, which implies that China should not take any sides, as China must remain neutral and develop the Ice silk road on the basis that the Arctic is open for everyone. What is more, relations with Russia should be developing cautiously and softly in order to achieve stable relations with Nordic countries as well, as relations with Nordic countries are essential to challenge the American strategy of worsening the image of China in the region. Moreover, authors perceive the EU as an important player

in the region which could coordinate and balance the relations between the US and China.

The issue of Chinese attitude towards the Arctic is also widely popular among both Western and non-Western scholars. Karlusov (2012) stated that Chinese researchers claim that the Arctic region should become more internationalized and should be governed by the principles of international law, which implies the equality between Arctic states, which have special rights and other states, which as China hold expeditions in the region.

Chircop (2011) noted that political interests of China in the region are driven by economic ones, such as maritime trade, resource extraction and access to the energy resources. Still, to be engaged in the Arctic affairs China uses its scientific research as a way to communicate with Arctic states, showing Chinese potential. Moreover, China also aims to gain support from developing states, as it constantly refers to the international law as the main source to regulate the region, claiming that the Arctic is international and any state has rights to participate in decision-making.

Li (2015) studied the prospects of Chinese participation in resource extraction in the Arctic. According to his view, the Chinese government has to focus on the elaboration of the strategy of Arctic resource usage simultaneously with the continuation of strengthening cooperation with state exporters of energy resources. The author noted that with rising energy prices, traditional oil and gas exploration and gathering routes are shrinking or even on the verge of depletion, thus the Arctic region should be considered as ‘the last energy base of the humankind’ (‘人类最后的能樨基地’). Moreover, the extraction of energy resources from the Arctic region would break existing international supply chains and thus, it is crucial to elaborate new regulatory bases. Moreover, Li (2015) highlighted that China perceives the Arctic region a valuable asset for all humankind, despite the fact that Arctic states are aimed to use Non-Arctic states to overcome their domestic capital and market issues to enhance their resource extraction activities. Moreover, the issue of ice melting increases the interest of

non-Arctic states such as India, Japan and South Korea in resource extraction and shipping, thus it is crucial for China to increase the level of cooperation with these states.

Lu (2011) also claimed that China perceives the issue of ice melting as a threat to the wellbeing of China, as it has direct impact on Chinese ecosystems, their food security and production. Therefore, author perceive ice melting as unconditional security threat for the PRC. Another important variable, which affects Chinese behaviour in the region is shipping, as most important maritime routes are located near the Southern part of China. However, as Northern regions of China are located closer to the Arctic, maritime routes could play an important role in development of Chinese regions.

Yang (2014) stated Chinese participation in Arctic activities should be directed to increase the state's potential and reflect the notion of China as a great power on several levels. On the global level China should take part in managing the Arctic environment, climate change and environmental protection within the framework of international organisation such as the UN. On the regional level China should strengthen its relations with the Arctic council by promoting the necessity of extraterritorial actors' involvement. On the bilateral level China should cooperate with Arctic states in the fields of science and technology and economy in order to gradually become more involved in Arctic affairs.

Ding & Zhao (2014) provided another vision of the PRC participation in the Arctic, which should be based on the Chinese identity as the 'international provider of common goods', as China is interested in win-win cooperation with its partners, which would allow further development of the region.

Ding & Zhang (2016) continued the issue of Chinese participation in Arctic affairs, considering the possibility of establishing new institutes to gain more power in decision-making. Hence the concept of 'Panarctic community' which would allow China to create a new identity as a state, capable of possessing a considerable amount of power in the Arctic. Thus, China should promote the

creation of a new organization with a unique structure, which is not based on the interests of Arctic states.

The issue of balance of power in the Arctic region is also widely popular among scholars. According to Conley & Melino (2021) there exist two key points which affect the balance of power in the region. The first one is signing the Ilulissat declaration by five Arctic states, which provided them with the rights to delimitate the outer continental shelf, to protect the environment, to hold scientific researches in the maritime area and conduct free navigation. Another turning point which was highlighted by the authors is the admission of China to the Arctic Council in 2013, after which the PRC proclaimed itself as a 'near-Arctic state'. Using this status, China managed to increase its economic and military presence in the region. Thus, authors suggest that within several years, China would reach the level of influence of Russia in the Arctic.

Hence the research gap of the study is the analysis of discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs within 2013-2024 from the constructivist perspective, as due to the lack of studies of CCP representatives' discourse on further involvement in Arctic affairs from the theoretical perspective, there exists little information on interdependence of Chinese discourse and its decision-making in the region within a given period. Thus, the understanding of the process of integrating the Arctic agenda into Chinese foreign policy strategy is crucial for further understanding of Chinese behavior internationally.

The research question of the study is: How did the discourse of representatives of CCP on the Arctic region transform within 2013-2024?

Research structure

This study consists of 3 parts. Chapter 1 focuses on methodology, theoretical framework of the study and historical context of Chinese involvement in Arctic affairs. Chapter 2 focuses on preconditions and continuity of Chinese Arctic policies within the timeframe from 2013 to 2017. Chapter 3 provides the analysis of the speeches of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs within the period of 2018-2024.

Chapter 1 Methodological, theoretical and historical framework of the study

1.1. Methodology

Disclaimer: In this work I used an AI-based DeepL translator to make correct translations from foreign languages

The research is based on the analysis of discourse of Chinese representatives of Communist Party of China to provide a comprehensive study of discourse transformation, analyzing factors which influence the behaviour of China and its self-perception in Arctic affairs. The data taken for the research are transcripts of speeches, interviews and statements made by Chinese officials within a given period. The data was taken from the websites of the government of China, the official website of Xinhua News agency and from the website of the ministry of foreign affairs of China. All the data was collected and analyzed in the Chinese language to preserve the original meaning. To make the proper translation in English, the DeepL translator was used. The qualitative method of data collection was used to take into analysis more relevant data based on the timeframe, which should be from 2013 to 2024, actor, who should be the representative of the Chinese Communist Party, and topic as this work considers the data on the Arctic issues.

This study includes two main methods. The first one is policy analysis, which is needed to understand how and why certain policies were adopted within the existing external political environment and how it affected this environment. According to Browne et. al (2019) there exist three branches of policy analysis where each of them is oriented on different analytical focus, data sources and methods. Thus, traditional policy analysis is based on facts viewing policy as an authoritative choice and hence taking into consideration behavioral psychology of its actors and rational approach. This approach does not include the role of values in the framework, aiming to make the outcomes more objective. The second branch of policy analysis is a mainstream one, where political processes, political networks, decision-making and governance processes are at the centre of research.

This approach is based on the perception of values and the role of political actors, as it aims to study the process of political interaction. The third branch is the interpretive one, which focuses on the meanings of particular policies, analyzing how policies are identified and framed within governmental discourse. In this study, the interpretive orientation of policy analysis is applied to study the relations between official Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs and decision-making. Moreover, as authors stated, in interpretive policy analysis, policy issues are considered to emerge due to historical and cultural factors. Also, Hastings (1998) stated that in this approach discourse and argumentation are taken into account as an integral part of decision-making process, thus, claiming that interpretive policy analysis is a method to study official discourse using statements, documents, and transcripts of speeches of officials, as well as to combine it with the discourse analysis, which is also another method used in the study. In addition, interpretive policy analysis allows to study frames within the discourse. According to Rein & Schön (1993) frames are based on actor's beliefs and perceptions which also affect the decision-making.

The second method used in this study is discourse analysis, which is essential to analyze the meaning of words in speeches of CCP representatives that were published by Xinhua News Agency, the government of the PRC and MFA of the PRC. Discourse analysis allows to study goals and motivations of policymakers, as Hansen (2013) stated that foreign policy actors are aimed to present a foreign policy which would be considered as most appropriate and legitimate for the population. Hence, the author claimed, that policymakers use the state's identity to make their actions more legitimate in the eyes of the population. State's identity is not always based on historical heritage, but may be adjusted to modern reality. Moreover, as Hansen (2013) outlined, for any fact based on a state's interests and identity to become influential to foreign policy it is essential to be collected and distributed by media, individuals or institutions. Moreover, Kristeva (1980) created a concept of intertextuality, which implies that all the official foreign policy statements and speeches are not isolated, but rather located within the societal

discourse, which also includes academic articles and journalist works. Thus, discourse analysis of this study is based not only on the materials provided by the MOFA and the government of China, but also by the Xinhua News agency, which is one of the most influential media in China dedicated to political affairs.

1.1.2. Potential shortcomings, limitations and expected outcomes

One potential shortcoming of this study is overemphasis on the role of representatives of Chinese Communist Party in shaping the direction of Chinese politics in the Arctic region. Thus, the role of discourse among representatives of entrepreneurships and business are not taken into consideration in a full sense.

This research also has several limitations. One of them is the fact that the study provides analysis of speeches made only by representatives of CCP. Another limitation is the timeframe from 2013 to 2024.

The expected outcomes of the research are the analysis of the transformation of the CCP representatives' discourse on the Arctic region within the period of 2013-2024. Moreover, another expected outcome is the analysis of the role of Chinese identity in shaping Arctic policies of China which would provide an understanding of Chinese decision-making process within their foreign policy.

1.2. Theoretical framework

The theory of constructivism was applied to this study in order to analyze factors which shape the CCP representatives' discourse on Arctic affairs. One of the main features of the constructivist theory is that it allows us to analyze the role of a state's identity in its foreign policy making. As Wendt (1992) stated, constructivism is a theory of international relations, which puts identities of the states at the centre of their interaction. Moreover, according to Wendt (1999), international structure is shaped by the ideas and perceptions of its actors and therefore state's interests and identities are developing within the process of interaction. Thus, in constructivism state's interests and identity as well as their influence on state's discourse and decision-making have larger influence than material factors.

Kratochwil (2018) argued that the state's identity is shaped by its historical background which also determined the attitude of the state towards its further strategy and development. Moreover, Kratochwil (2018) claimed that as the knowledge, wishes, skills and identities of individuals are different and unique they should be studied separately, without aiming to establish causal relations between various occasions. However, as Kristeva (1980) outlined, that speeches of officials are not isolated, but rather existing in the discourse within the society. Therefore, actions of individuals could also be considered as a response or reaction to other actions or statements made within the state or in the international system. Thus, this study aims to analyze the role of discourse on continuity of Chinese Arctic policies, considering representatives of Communist Party of China as actors of the discourse, who provide consistent policy based on the state's interests and identity.

However, the role of identity may be ambiguous as Latin (1998) argued that identity is not always socially constructed, as it may also be chosen by the actors based on their current needs. Thus, the role of identity is still one of the major variables in constructivist theory, but its origins should be studied in every case

separately, considering also major points which affected the policy shift and dynamics.

Jepperson et. al (1996) recognized the role of norms and practices within the international system in the constructivist perspective. Authors claimed that understanding of actors and development of the relations between them happens through the usage of norms and practices. Hence norms and practices are the tools to shape identity of the state, which allow to define which actions of one state would make other actors respond in a manner that the state expects.

Habermas (2003) supported the idea of combining discourse analysis and constructivist theory, as he studied the role of discourse in international relations, claiming that arguments provided by the states are also socially constructed and thus constructivist theory is applicable to the discourse analysis as it provides more comprehensive study of the process. Thus, in studies where the identity has the main role in shaping the behavior of the state, discourse analysis could be useful in revealing interests, motivations and incentives of the actors.

Finnemore & Sikkink (2001) also pointed out that discourse plays a major role in elaborating new social understanding of politics and its processes as well as bringing new social norms. Thus, the developing discourse of China on its role in the Arctic as a near-Arctic state and Arctic stakeholder could be considered as a new approach towards further integration of China in regional and global politics.

1.3. Historical context of the Chinese involvement in Arctic affairs

The perception of the Arctic region as a part of Chinese political discourse and the role that China should take in the Arctic has undergone significant changes throughout recent decades. What is more, Chinese modern vision of the Arctic region was shaped by previously existing ideas and logic behind them. Therefore, in order to provide a comprehensive understanding of Chinese discourse and policy making under the presidency of Xi Jinping, it is essential to study the history of Chinese involvement in the Arctic region. Moreover, as according to the constructivist theory actors have influence on state's identity and state's interests, the changing perception of the Arctic within Chinese policymaking could partly be a result of the influence of political leaders and their ability to react to changes in the external environment. Hence, this study provides an overview of the transformation of Chinese attitude towards the Arctic region since the last decades of the XX century.

According to Liu (2021) one of the first attempts of China to engage in Arctic affairs was in 1925 when China joined the Svalbard treaty which allowed states to participate in commercial activities on the territory of Svalbard. Still, the impact of Chinese involvement in the Arctic region was not high up to the establishment of Chinese Arctic and Antarctic administration (CAA), which was opened as the result of Deng Xiaoping openness reform[1]. The CAA aimed to coordinate all Chinese Arctic programmes and elaborate Chinese Arctic strategy. According to Zuenko (2024) in 1980s China established the Polar research institute of China, which coordinates polar stations and conducts researches about Arctics. Zuenko (2024) also stated that in 1994 China bought its first icebreaker 'Xuelong' from Ukraine, which for the first time traversed Northeast passage only in 2012, showing the increasing pace of Chinese engagement in Arctic affairs, as the "Xuelong" icebreaker became the first vehicle and platform of Chinese scientific missions in the Arctic region.

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[1] "About Us" Chinese Arctic and Antarctic Administration, accessed May 1, 2024, Retrieved from:https://web.archive.org/web/20100307224446/http://www.chinare.gov.cn/en/index.html?pid=about

The modest involvement of China in Arctic affairs could be also explained by the bipolar world order which left no opportunities for third states to promote stable Arctic policies. Hence, according to Bertelsen (2025) during the 20th century the Arctic region was divided between two superpowers, the USSR and the US leaving other states no possibility to accumulate their power in the region. Bertelsen (2025) outlined that the cooperation between 5 Arctic states was regulated by several agreements, such as the Polar Bear Treaty which was signed in 1973 to preserve the existing population of polar bears as well as to regulate ecological environment and ship passage. Hence, the approach towards Arctic governance during the Cold War was primarily based on the realist perception of the world order by both the US and the USSR, which lasted up to the end of Cold War, when as Bertelsen (2022) stated, the existing order changed due to the post Cold War dynamics, as the US established Western-led governmental institutions in the Arctic based on liberal perception of the world order. Thus, China had to integrate into these organizations in order to increase its influence and promote itself as a powerful state.

Kienko (2019) stated that in 1996 China became a member of the International Arctic Science Committee to cooperate with other states in Arctic research as well as to increase its role in the Arctic region and highlight to other states the capability of the PRC to be a player in the Arctic. Kienko (2019) also noted that in 2004 the first Chinese scientific research station called Yellow River was built, thus increasing the number of Chinese researchers in the Arctic as well as promoting China as a provider of scientific knowledge and possible partner in the Arctic region.

According to Lanteigne & Ping (2015) the rapid involvement in Arctic affairs coincided with the start of Chinese naval strategy proclaimed by former Chinese president Hu Jintao, which implied conceptualization of missions, values and priorities of the People’s Liberation Army Navy. Lanteigne & Ping (2015) outlined that the improvement of Chinese naval power along with Chinese rhetoric on the interpretation of UNCLOS which implies that all the states have a right to

be engaged in the Arctic affairs as the Arctic should be open to every state led to changing in perception of China by other states considering China as an expansionist state. However, authors claimed that China has its core interests which are located in the East and South China seas and that is why the PRC behaves in a more active and aggressive manner near its borders, whereas the Arctic region is not considered by China as a part of its core interests.

Nevertheless, from the beginning of the 21th century China gradually started to consider the Arctic region as an important part of its foreign policy, thus aiming to shape the vision of China as a state with a right to participate in the Arctic governance. Thus, Kornev (2022) outlined that in the early 2000s China created a vertical map of the world, which helped to visualize Chinese attitude towards modern geopolitical situations. Thus, the vertical map of the world shows the proximity of China to the Arctic region, implying that from the perspective of the vertical map, China is relatively closer to the Arctic. Moreover, Kornev (2022) states that in 2010 China started its fourth Arctic scientific expedition which was oriented on acquiring the information about possible negative drawbacks of ice melting in the Arctic region, which is relevant for all states including China, and thus China as a large state with sufficient level of economic and scientific capabilities has to address this issue. Kornev (2022) also highlighted that within this period China started to expand its influence on resource extraction, as in 2010 the Chinese government started considering the participation in the exploration of the Arctic resources, thus aiming to improve its relations with the Arctic states.

Another important part of Chinese Arctic discourse is the creation of concepts to legitimize Chinese presence in the region. The first concept was “near-Arctic state” (“近北极国家”), which according to Shuang (2021) started to be used by Chinese scientists since 2010 to define the states with geographical proximity to Arctic region and maritime routes. Still, the concept did not have defined criteria for states to be called ‘Near-Arctic states’. Therefore, as Shuang (2021) outlined, the Chinese government shifted to the concept of “Arctic stakeholder” (“北极利益攸关者”) which left more opportunities for Chinese

government and entrepreneurs to continue their actions in Arctic. Both concepts are analyzed in the next chapter of the study to study how the Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs was shaped within 2013-2024.

1.4. Relations between China and Arctic states

To provide a comprehensive analysis of the transformation of the discourse of representatives of Communist Party of China on Arctic affairs, this study includes an overview of relations between China and eight Arctic states.

1.4.1. US-China relations in the Arctic region

Bertelsen (2025) outlined two major approaches towards further development of Sino-American relations after the growth of China became noticeable in the late 1990s. The first vision was presented 25 years ago by Joseph Nye, who was liberal institutionalist and policy maker in the administration of president Clinton claimed that China would eventually integrate in Western-dominated institutions and would have to preserve the existing world order as China already did by entering the WTO as a result of its economic growth. Nye awaited further openness and liberalisation of the PRC as a result of its economic growth, which, as the author stated, proved to be false and ethnocentric. There was another approach towards further dynamics of Chinese foreign policy which would directly affect its behavior in the Arctic region, which was presented by John Mearsheimer, who outlined that the US should pursue the containment strategy against China in order to prevent its straightening and becoming a regional hegemon in East Asia. This vision explains modern trade wars and competition in the spheres of science and technology between two states, as well as Chinese foreign policy behaviour based on establishing non-Western-led world order by creating non-Western international organizations such as the Shanghai Cooperation Organization and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank to establish parallel institutions with the Western ones in order to achieve the leading role in the Asian region, as well as in other regions through the Belt and Road Initiative.

As nowadays both China and the US are two largest world economies, there is no doubt that their competition also expands on the Arctic region. The US aims to prevent increasing influence of China on Arctic states, as Bertelsen (2025) states that the US pressures the Kingdom of Denmark to not accept Chinese investments and reject proposals from Chinese to rent territory of Denmark. Hence the US

aims to prevent further integration of China into the system of Arctic governance, as well as the increase of its participation of its companies in building infrastructure on the territory of Arctic states and the number of Chinese research bases and missions in the Arctic region. According to US Department of Defense (2019) the US in their Arctic strategy outlined that China poses a threat to Arctic security, as China has no legal basis for its presence in Arctic and the US does not recognize the Chinese concept of 'Near-Arctic state', but the PRC despite having no military presence in the region, still aims to get more power in the Arctic by making investments in projects of Arctic states and promoting BRI initiative, thus using the Arctic region to achieve their strategic goals, which could also imply that the Arctic region becomes a part of Chinese strategic interests. Such a vision of China by the US was continued in the next US Arctic Strategy, which was published in 2022. According to White House (2022) the US is concerned about China continuing to engage in Arctic affairs, especially taking into account the fact that the PRC expanded its icebreaker fleet and for the first time Chinese naval vessels reached the Arctic. According to US Department of Defense (2024), for the US it is important to address the issue of cooperation between Russia and China in the Arctic region. Moreover, according to US Department of Defense (2024), it is necessary to prevent the threat of Chinese presence in the region, which stresses that the US preserves China as a competitor despite its attempts to frame their activities in the Arctic as a mutually beneficial cooperation.

1.4.2. Russia-China relations in the Arctic region

The Russia-China relations in the Arctic region faced significant improvement over the last decades. Sheng (2022) noted that since 2008 the level of cooperation between China and Russia has been increasing. Also, both states share a similar vision of the world order standing against hegemony and promoting multipolar world order. Major directions of China-Russia partnership are trade, traditional security where China and Russia hold joint military exercises, and non-traditional security. Consequently, such types of bilateral activities led to cooperation in other spheres, such as Russia's support of the BRI initiative. As

Kulintsev (2023) stated, China perceives Russia as one of its most important partners, as China understands that the development of the EAEU is one of the major goals for Russia, where China could provide investments in EAEU projects and economic assistance in economic recovery of Russian regions, such as Siberia and Far East, which would make the cooperation between two states mutually beneficial.

Kolzina & Mindubaeva (2020) highlighted the importance of the Polar Silk Road in the development of Russia-China relations in the Arctic. Thus, according to Kolzina & Mindubaeva (2020), Polar Silk Road, is a continuation of One Belt One Road Initiative, aimed at developing Arctic shipping routes. However, as the Polar Silk Road is partly located at the Russian shipping lanes, Russia becomes an important partner in the project. What is more, Kolzina & Mindubaeva (2020) also stated that China is developing Arctic tourism, which is also beneficial for Russia, as it could provide more opportunities for the commercial exploitation of the Northern Sea Route (NSR).

However, the form of integration of NSR into the Polar Silk Road is not defined yet, as the NSR is vital for Russian strategic interests. Another important factor which influences the cooperation within the BRI frameworks is the perception of the NSR by the two states, as according to Strelnikova (2025) China shares the vision that the Arctic is open for everyone, whereas Russia considers that Arctic states have exclusive rights to the Arctic region. Hence, such fundamental difference in the approach towards the NSR flowers the pace of cooperation between two states. Devyatkin (2024) also wrote about the fact, that China, similar to the US, consider NSR as a part of international waters, such vision together with the existence of espionage cases such as the arrest of the President of Russia's Arctic Academy of Sciences Valery Mitko in 2020, when he was accused of sharing state secret technologies with the PRC make author come to the conclusion that the cooperation between China and Russia in the Arctic region is limited due to the strategic reasons.

Nevertheless, Wang (2022) states that for China it is relatively easier to expand its influence in Arctic affairs through Russia than through any other Arctic state. Therefore, China invests a lot into the Russian Arctic, especially in mining and shipping. China invested into the building of a deep-water seaport in Arkhangelsk which would be a base for Chinese Arctic shipping. Therefore, the cooperation between Russia and China in the Arctic region could be considered as strategically beneficial for both sides, but still as Kopra & Puranen (2021) stated Russia does not aim at having a strong Chinese presence in their Arctic, thus making the relations between two states more complicated.

1.4.3. China-Finland relations on the Arctic region

According to Koivurova et. al (2019), despite the fact that Finland was one of the first Western states to recognize the PRC and establish diplomatic relations in 1952, due to the existence of the Agreement of Friendship, Cooperation, and Mutual Assistance between the Soviet Union and Finland which lasted from 1948 to 1992 the relations between Finland and China were moderate. Only after the openness reforms carried out by Deng Xiaoping did the main development of Sino-Finnish relations begin. Koivurova et. al (2019) also claimed that the cooperation between two states in the Arctic region increased after the visit of president Xi in Finland in 2017, as the leaders signed a joint declaration, marking areas in which further development is prioritized. Among such sectors are energy, tourism and winter sports. During the visit several sectoral agreements were signed to provide a legal basis for cooperation in trade and technology. Such actions are in line with the Arctic strategy of Finland, which was published in 2013. According to the Finland Prime Minister’s office (2013), the bilateral cooperation with non-Arctic states is considered to be beneficial for Finland.

One of the main directions of cooperation between China and Finland in the Arctic region is partnership in the scientific field. According to Koivurova et. al (2019) as China always considers climate change as one of the main issues which it should cover in the Arctic, the PRC actively engages in scientific research and is open for cooperation with other states. Therefore in 2013 the China-Nordic Arctic

Research Centre (CNARC) was opened in Shanghai to create a platform through which scientists from Lapland collaborate with Chinese researchers. Koivurova et. al (2019) also noted that these researches are not primarily concerned with the issue of climate change, as some authors of this report were also engaged in the research conducted by the Arctic Centre of the University of Lapland and Wuhan university on the comparison of legal positions of states of the European Union, the PRC and Finland towards major Arctic issues such as shipping, fishing and the rights of indigenous population in the Arctic. Hence in some areas of cooperation, such as the scientific one, the relations between two states are stable developing.

Nevertheless, Finland being the part of the European Union and NATO also questions the motivation behind Chinese participation in Arctic affairs as well as does not want to threaten interests of Finland and raise the dependency of its Arctic regions on Chinese investments. As Kopra & Puranen (2021) stated, in 2018 the Polar Research Institute of China aimed to buy or rent the Airport near the city Kemijarvi, located in the Eastern Lapland. However, the deal was blocked by the Finnish Defence forces due to their security concerns, as Kemijarvi is located near the main Finnish artillery range Rovajrvi. The authors implied that building the infrastructure near the airport and creation of scientific base on the territory of Kemijarvi would allow China to large expand their influence in the region, improving the Chinese polar military capabilities, as the PRC is still developing its own navigation system BeiDou2 and needs more data before starting to increase its military presence in the Arctic region, basically moving its strategic nuclear submarines to patrol under the polar ice.

Moreover, as Kopra & Puranen (2021) outlined, the official proclamation of China of its identity of ‘Near-Arctic state’ in White Paper on the Arctic region in 2018 led to increased suspicions on true ambitions of China from the Arctic states. As five out of eight Arctic states are members of NATO, they are unwilling to let China invest into critical infrastructure of their Arctic territories, making them more dependent on the Chinese side.

1.4.4. Sino-Danish relations in the Arctic

Modern relations between China and Denmark in the Arctic region are characterized by the necessity for China to diversify its relations with Arctic states in order to get international recognition as an Arctic player as well as to increase its presence in the region by establishing new scientific bases and holding bilateral projects with Denmark. Moreover, China needs resources located in Greenland such as iron ore and uranium to develop their domestic industries and increase the pace of production. Therefore, China had a long strategy of establishing stable and good relations with the Dutch government. In 2008 Joint Statement Between China and Denmark on Establishment of Comprehensive Strategic Partnership[2] was signed to promote comprehensive strategic partnership between two states, deepening trade relations between two states and highlighting joint cooperation in the field of climate change and environmental protection, thus creating a legal base for further projects in the Arctic region. However, in the second half of 2010s the level of cooperation between two states started to decrease. It happened due to the fact, that as Bertelsen (2025) stated, Denmark is willing to limit the possibilities of Greenland to acquire more power and influence, thus becoming able to make policies less dependent on Denmark or starting to rely on other states such as China which could contribute to the rapid growth of the economy of Greenland, becoming an influencer in the region. Moreover, Bertelsen (2025) highlighted, that relations between Denmark and the USA affect possible involvement of China in the development of Greenland, as the US aims to limit the rising power of the PRC in the region through influencing bilateral relations between China and pro-Western states such as Denmark. Bertelsen (2025) analyzed the example of the Chinese proposition to establish a research station in Greenland, which would consist of a satellite ground station. The government of Greenland welcomed this proposition, whereas the Denmark government reacted negatively to such an idea. As Bertelsen (2025) outlined, both Denmark and the US would never allow China to build a research station or satellite station in interest as it contradicts with

[2] "Joint Statement Between China and Denmark on Establishment of Comprehensive Strategic Parnership" China Internet Information Center, accessed May 1, 2025, Retrieved from: http://www.china.org.cn/government/news/2008-10/25/content_16664479.htm

the Danish perception of security as well as with the US strategic interests. Therefore, the US Department of Defense made pressure on the Danish government to reject the Chinese proposition. Bislev et. al (2018) also pointed to the strategic importance of Greenland in the relations between Denmark and the US, claiming that both American and Danish sides would not let China engage in large investment projects in order to preserve status quo in the region. Kopra & Puranen (2021) also claimed that unwillingness of the Dutch government to let China engage in providing investments and building infrastructure in Greenland could be explained by the threat of getting Greenland dependent on Chinese investments as well as getting stable relations between the PRC and Greenland, whereas Greenland as an autonomous region aims to cooperate more with China in order to become less dependent on Denmark.

What is more, the scientific direction of cooperation between China and Denmark also faces significant decline, as Bertelsen (2025) noted that nowadays Denmark does not participate in China Nordic Arctic Research Center (CNARC), as the Nordic institute of Asian studies at the University of Copenhagen was closed, leaving less possibilities to promote bilateral scientific cooperation. Therefore, modern relations between two states are moderate due to the increased suspicions of Denmark towards Chinese actions in the Arctic region and American aspirations to protect Greenland from Chinese influence.

1.4.5. Sino-Icelandic relations in the Arctic

China and Iceland share a history of cooperation in the Arctic region, focusing on mutually beneficial cooperation and development of the Arctic region. The cooperation increased since 2013 when Iceland signed a free trade agreement with China[3] , thus supporting the observer status of the PRC in the Arctic Council. After that both sides put a lot of effort into creation and maintenance of good relations and partnership in the region, as Nielsen (2019) outlined that China is

[3] "Free Trade Agreement between Iceland and China" Government of Iceland, accessed May 1, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.government.is/topics/foreign-affairs/external-trade/free-trade-agreements/free-trade-agreement-between-iceland-and-china/

interested in Icelandic studies on clean energy and Arctic science to cooperate in the sphere of climate change and environment protection, which reflects Chinese adherence to its initial aims of dealing with these challenges as a global power. What is more, Bertelsen (2025) also claimed that 2013 was a turning point in Sino-Icelandic partnership in the Arctic region, as after the official visit of Chinese premier Wen Jiabao to Iceland both sides agreed to establish the China Nording Arctic Research Center in 2013, using CNARC as a platform for meetings of China and Nordic states on the topic of Arctic affairs. Bertelsen (2025) also pointed to the creation of China Iceland Arctic Observatory (CIAO), which opened in 2018 in Karholl to study aurora and upper atmosphere research. However, the collaboration was complicated by the COVID-19 pandemic. The author also claimed that nowadays the US pressures Iceland to close the CIAO to stop Chinese engagement in Arctic affairs.

Nevertheless, the government of Iceland is interested in cooperation with China. As Hastings (2014) stated, Iceland considers the Arctic as an instrument through which it can achieve significant gains and boost its economy. Therefore, as the author emphasized, Iceland uses the concept of ‘coastal Arctic state’ to show its identity as an Arctic player. Thus, Iceland strives for promotion of Arctic tourism not only due to the economic benefits, but also to frame Iceland as a coastal Arctic state in the international discourse and increase overall global visibility of a state. Hence, unlike other European states, Iceland mostly considers China not as a threat but as an opportunity to raise its position on the international arena. Moreover, Hastings (2014) claimed that Iceland considers that China is aware of the risks given by climate change, as the rise of sea level and climate shifts could directly affect the well-being of the PRC. Therefore, Iceland perceives China as a state which is aimed to mitigate the risks in order to overcome possible threat of climate change drawbacks.

1.4.6. Sino-Swedish relations in the Arctic

According to Zakhariev (2018), initially the relations between China and Sweden were moderate due to political tensions, such as the conflict which

emerged after Chinese dissident Liu Xiaobo was awarded with the Nobel Peace prize in 2010. Zakhariev (2018) also implies that the relations between two states shifted to a more positive dynamic in 2013, when the administration of president Xi came to power. Zakhariev also (2018) outlined that for China the cooperation with Sweden in fields of space and navigation is important, as for the PRC the usage of satellites is crucial in provisioning of accurate navigation routes for its ships. Bertelsen (2025) also considers scientific cooperation as an important part of Sino-Swedish cooperation in the region, as in 2016 the China Remote Sensing Satellite North Polar Ground Station (CNPGS) was built near Kiruna city on the Swedish territory of Lapland. The author noted that the creation of such a system raised the efficiency of satellite data transmission, leaving for China more possibilities to improve their maritime navigation.

As Bertelsen (2025) outlined, Sweden had withdrawn from China Nordic Arctic Research Center (CNARC), decreasing the level of cooperation between two states in the Arctic.

1.4.7. Sino-Norwegian relations in the Arctic

Liu (2021) stated that Sino-Norwegian relations in the Arctic region started in 1925 when China joined the Svalbard treaty, enabling China to participate in resource exploration on the territory of Svalbard. However, according to Zakhariev (2018), nowadays Norway perceives this treaty in a negative way, as all parties of the treaty could exploit Svalbard, and China is largely involved in the resources extraction process in Svalbard.

Nevertheless, as China could invest in Arctic projects in Svalbard, Norway cooperates with the PRC to modernize the infrastructure of its Arctic territories and accumulate investments. Hence, Zuenko (2024) highlighted that in 2003 China established its first research base called the Yellow River on the territory of the Arctic. Through the base China conducts research on issues of climate change and

development of polar technology. The base also cooperates with China Nordic Arctic Research Center (CNARC) with Norway as a member[4].

Another important point of cooperation between China and Norway in the Arctic is the possible exploitation of Kirkiness by China. As Zakhariev (2018) outlined, China aims to use Kirkenes city for ship transition, as Kirkes has more developed infrastructure that Murmansk.

However, the relations between two states are influenced by the US aspirations to control Arctic order. Therefore Zakhariev (2018) wrote that nowadays the US wants to minimize the export of technologies such as deep-water drilling rigs and ecological fishery from Norway to Russia and China. Thus, the US attempts to slow the pace of cooperation between China and Norway as well as Norwegian perception of the PRC as a possible threat to the existing order limits the level of partnership between two states, still leaving room for joint research and infrastructure projects.

1.4.8. China-Canada relations in the Arctic

Zakhariev (2018) claimed that PRC cooperates least with the US and Canada in the Arctic region, where unlike US, Canada has no independent cooperation with the PRC in the Arctic region. Therefore, according to Zakhariev (2018), Canada as a US ally often aims to limit Chinese involvement in Arctic affairs withing the framework of the Arctic council. Despite that, Zakhariev (2018) considered that China could potentially develop infrastructure of Canadian Arctic territories, which is beneficial for Canada and China as well, as China aims to diversify its relations with Arctic states.

What is more, as Zakhariev (2018) outlined, the large Chinese community could play a main role in improving relations between two states, as the Chinese Community in Canada is integrated in the domestic economy and decision-making, which provides more opportunities for Chinese companies and enterprises to collaborate with Canadian companies. Thus, the usage of already existing channels

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[4] "Nordic members" China-Nordic Arctic Research Center, accessed May 1, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.cnarc.info/members/nordic-members

of communication such as the Chinese community could allow China to increase the level of cooperation with Canada.

1.5. Chapter conclusion

In conclusion, within several decades China managed to gradually develop its presence in the Arctic region by starting scientific expeditions, signing contracts with foreign companies and improving bilateral relations with Arctic states. China presents its involvement in Arctic affairs as a win-win cooperation for Arctic states to achieve mutually beneficial gains. The main aspects of cooperation are environmental protection, development of maritime routes and Arctic studies. Nevertheless, the cooperation is limited due to the fact that many Arctic states, especially European ones, perceive China as a possible threat, thus preventing its dominance in the region.

The foreign policy direction chosen by president Xi after he came to power in 2013 has significantly changed bilateral relations with Arctic states. Xi's administration managed to resolve old conflicts, such as the dispute with Sweden over the Nobel Peace prize award in 2010 given to Chinese dissident Liu Xiaobo. Moreover, China aims to establish channels for long-term relations with Arctic countries, still aiming to diversify its relations with as many Arctic states as possible. Also, such actions help China in achieving international recognition as an Arctic player. Nevertheless, such actions from the Chinese side faces constraints from the USA, as the US aims to limit cooperation of China with other Arctic states in order to prevent it from growing its presence in the region, as for the US both China and China-Russia activities in the Arctic region are considered as a threat.

Chapter 2 The Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs within the period of 2013-2017

Introduction

The start of the presidency of Xi Jinping in 2013 led to the increasing role of China in the Arctic region, as president Xi's administration was aimed to maintain already existing channels of involvement in Arctic affairs, such as scientific expeditions, joint projects with Arctic states, including investments in their infrastructure. Therefore, during this period the PRC aimed to diversify the channels of its presence in the region as well as deepen the cooperation with Arctic and Non-Arctic states to justify its presence in the region. Simultaneously with that, the PRC proceeded with bridging its actions in the Arctic region with domestic discourse, aligning it with broader policies, such as the necessity to reach the Community of Common Destiny for Mankind, which was proclaimed by Xi Jinping in 2012[5]. This chapter analyzes speeches and statements of Chinese officials published by the PRC Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MFA), the Government of the PRC and Xinhua news agency which were published within the period of 2013-2017.

The aims of this chapter are to analyze main directions of Chinese Arctic policies and the discourse around them to highlight continuity and transformation within the discourse during the period of 2013-2017, starting with the compliance of the discourse with its direction in previous periods, then outlining major changes in the discourse since the beginning of Xi Jinping's presidency, next studying the impact of the concept of Community of Common Destiny for Mankind on Arctic discourse of CCP representatives and finally analyzing the discourse around environmental policies in the Arctic region.

2.1. Compliance with previous direction of the discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs

[5] "Writing a New Chapter of Peaceful Development -- 10th Anniversary of President Xi Jinping's Concept of Building a Community of Human Destiny" People's daily, accessed May 1, 2025, Retrieved from: http://politics.people.com.cn/n1/2023/0325/c1001-32651059.html [谱写和平发展新篇章——习近平主席提出构建人类命运共同体理念十周年]

To analyze the continuity and change in the discourse of Chinese representatives of CCP on Arctic affairs it is essential to understand which trends in Chinese discourse on arctic affairs, which were used in previous periods, remained in the period of 2013-2017.

2.1.1. China as a good party to international treaties and organizations

Participation of China in international treaties in the Arctic region has a long history starting from the Svalbard treaty which, according to Liu (2021), China joined in 1925. Therefore, the Chinese government continued the long strategy of participation in international agreements in order to be considered as a reliable actor which behavior is aligned with international treaties and legal framework. Moreover, the emphasis on adherence to the international legal environment and the status of participants in Arctic treaties allows China to legitimize their presence in the Arctic region, alongside with its membership in Arctic organizations. Hence, Chinese policymakers referred to Svalbard treaty and the status of China as an observer in the Arctic Council as to the reason for the justification of the necessity for China to participate in the process of the development of the region and the mechanisms of its governance[6].

What is more, as main directions of Chinese Arctic policies are environmental protection and scientific projects, mostly concerning the issue of climate change and its possible consequences, Chinese politicians tended to highlight faithful fulfilling the terms of Vienna Convention for the Protection of the Ozone Layer, United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, Convention on Biological Diversity and other treaties which have direct influence on the protection of Arctic ecosystems[7]. For China it is also important to highlight that the PRC also participates in the creation of a new legal framework, such as the

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[6] "Deputy Director General of the State Oceanic Administration explains the Regulations on the Administration of Administrative Licences for Arctic Expedition Activities" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/zhengce/2017-09/20/content_5226465.htm [国家海洋局副局长解读《北极考察活动行政许可管理规定》]

[7] "Keynote address by Vice-Minister for Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming at the China country-specific session of the Third Circumpolar Forum General Assembly" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201510/t20151017_7945486.shtml [外交部副部长张明在"第三届北极圈论坛大会"中国国别专题会议上的主旨发言]

elaboration of the Polar Code, which is used for maritime shipping[8]. Such action not only aimed to highlight that the PRC is concerned about the process of Arctic governance, but also to outline that China is interested in global shipping and especially Arctic shipping, which also remains one of the main directions of Chinese Arctic policies[9]. What is more, Chinese policymakers denoted that any development of the Arctic region should be taken in accordance with international treaties and laws and in compliance with the domestic laws of the Arctic states[10].

2.1.2. China as a supporter of preserving the sovereignty and interests of Arctic states

Despite the increasing capabilities of China in the Arctic region, taking into consideration its investments and projects on the territory of Arctic states, Chinese politicians still outline that Arctic states have a leading role in the process of Arctic governance, including their status in the Arctic council, as well as the fact that Arctic states have sovereign rights on the Arctic territories which China respect, as China always respected interests, values and traditions of indigenous people in the Arctic region, thus considering them while proceeding with its Arctic policies[11]. Therefore in 2015 the Vice-Minister of Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming said that one of the political principles of further involvement in Arctic affairs is 'the respect for the inalienable rights of Arctic States and Arctic Indigenous Peoples' ('尊重北极国家和北极土著人的固有权利'[12]). Thus, Chinese policymakers stated that the well-being of indigenous population in the Arctic depends on the state of the Arctic ecosystem, and therefore China as an influencer player together with other states has to preserve the existing environmental conditions in order to protect

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[8] Ibid.
[9] Ibid.
[10] Ibid.
[11] "Foreign Ministry spokesman Hong Lei answers questions on the acceptance of China as an observer to the Arctic Council" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4,2025, Retrieved from:https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/fyrbt_673021/dhdw_673027/201305/t20130515_5432938.shtml [外交部发言人洪磊就北极理事会接受中国为观察员事答记者问]
[12] "Keynote address by Vice-Minister for Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming at the China country-specific session of the Third Circumpolar Forum General Assembly" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201510/t20151017_7945486.shtml [外交部副部长张明在"第三届北极圈论坛大会"中国国别专题会议上的主旨发言]

local populations[13]. Therefore, China in its discourse tended to highlight its attitude towards state's sovereignty and willingness to cooperate with Arctic states favouring their Arctic status.

2.1.3. China as a Near-Arctic state

Within the period of 2013-2017 the PRC continues to promote the idea of China being a "Near-Arctic state" ("近北极国家"). According to Shuang (2021), China has been using the concept of 'Near-Arctic state' by scientists since 2010 to legitimize Chinese increasing participation in Arctic affairs and to promote the idea of China being an actor in the Arctic region. Hence the representatives of the PRC proceeded with using this concept, claiming that geographically China is a 'Near-Arctic state' and therefore all the situations happening in the Arctic including environmental changes and resource extraction directly affect stability of China, as it covers all the spheres such as climate, agricultural productivity, shipping, trade and socio-economic development[14].

2.2. Discourse on Arctic affairs after the start of presidency of Xi Jinping

Within the period of 2013-2017 the discourse of Chinese policies in the Arctic region underwent changes due to the fact that the Xi Jinping administration brought change into the already existing strategy of Chinese Arctic policies. Therefore, this part of the chapter analyzes new trends and directions of the discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs. The study proceeds with the overview of main directions of CCP representatives' discourse on Arctic affairs and its main features which are depicted on the figure 1.

Discourse topic	**Year**	**Author**	**Main features**
China as a responsible great power	2017	Lin Shangqin, deputy director of the State Oceanic	1. China adheres to the principles of Arctic management.

[13] Ibid.
[14] Ibid.

		Administration	2. China has large material capabilities to participate in Arctic affairs. 3. Involvement of China in Arctic affairs is mutually beneficial
China as an 'Arctic stakeholder'	2017	Wang Yi, head of the MFAof the PRC	1. 'Arctic stakeholder' has a broader meaning than 'Near-Arctic state' 2. China is a 'participant', 'constructor' and 'contributor' in Arctic affairs.
Chinese cooperation in Arctic region	2015	Zhang Ming, Vice-Minister of Foreign Affairs of the PRC	1. China recognizes the sovereign rights and interests of Arctic states 2. China supports interests of international community and stands for multi-level system of Arctic governance 3. China supports rights and interests of the indigenous Arctic population 4. China adheres to the international law within the framework of Arctic governance
Arctic region within the	2015	Wang Yi, head of the MFA of the	1. Arctic development and stability benefit everyone

framework of the Community of Common destiny for Mankind		PRC	2. China has enough capabilities to maintain and improve its involvement in Arctic affairs
Environmental protection	2015	Zhang Ming, Vice-Minister of Foreign Affairs of the PRC	1. China puts effort in exploration of the Arctic and is open for cooperation 2. China supports sustainable usage and development of the Arctic region and its resources
Climate change	2017	Wang Yang, Vice Premier of the PRC	1. China pays attention towards climate change and ecology protection 2. China is ready to participate in improvement of institutional mechanisms of fighting climate change issue in the Arctic region

Thus, within the period of 2013-2017 the deputy director of the State Oceanic Administration Lin Shanqing claimed that China is a "responsible great power" ("负责任大国")[15], which adheres to principles of Arctic management and is able to participate in Arctic development, management and exploration due to its

[15] "Deputy Director General of the State Oceanic Administration explains the Regulations on the Administration of Administrative Licences for Arctic Expedition Activities" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/zhengce/2017-09/20/content_5226465.htm [国家海洋局副局长解读《北极考察活动行政许可管理规定》]

large material capabilities, thus helping to achieve beneficial outcomes for all Arctic players[16].

Another important part of the CCP representatives' discourse on Arctic affairs was the shift from the concept of 'Near-Arctic state' to the 'Arctic stakeholder', which happened in 2017 after the speech of Wang Yi, the head of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of China[17]. The idea of China being 'Arctic stakeholder' implies that this concept is broader than previous one, leaving less constraints on Chinese actions in the Arctic region[18]. Moreover, it allows China to change its perception in the region, highlighting that China contributes a lot of its efforts and finances in regional development, participates actively in bilateral projects with Arctic states, thus being able to participate in further construction of the Arctic system[19].

During this period within the political discourse of China the main features of Chinese cooperation in the Arctic region were proclaimed by the Vice-Minister of Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming[20]. Thus, it was stressed that China recognizes the rights and interests of Arctic states and indigenous population of the Arctic. In addition, China complies its actions in the region with international law and supports the idea of creation of a multi-level system of Arctic governance, thus taking into account the interests of the international community in the region[21].

What is more, this study analyses the connection between the discourse on Community of Common Destiny for Mankind and Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs. Main similarities were found in the speeches of Wang Yi, the head of Chinese MFA, who stated that the developed and stable Arctic region is beneficial

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[16] Ibid.

[17] "Statement by Minister Wang Yi at the Opening Ceremony of the Third Circumpolar Forum Assembly" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/guowuyuan/vom/2015-10/19/content_2950053.htm [王毅部长在第三届北极圈论坛大会开幕式上的致辞]

[18] Ibid.

[19] Ibid.

[20] "Keynote address by Vice-Minister for Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming at the China country-specific session of the Third Circumpolar Forum General Assembly" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201510/t20151017_7945486.shtml [外交部副部长张明在"第三届北极圈论坛大会"中国国别专题会议上的主旨发言]

[21] Ibid.

for everyone, thus pushing forward Arctic cooperation[22]. The role of China in the process of Arctic development was also highlighted as China has enough power and material capabilities to actively participate in Arctic affairs, which would lead to mutually beneficial outcomes[23].

The issue of environmental protection is also an important part of CCP representatives' discourse on Arctic affairs as Vice-Minister of Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming stated that China aims to explore the region and its peculiarities and is ready to cooperate with other interested parties[24]. Moreover, it was claimed that China supports the sustainable utilization of Arctic resources and sustainable development of the region[25].

Moreover, the issue of climate change is presented as one of the main directions of Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs, as the Vice Premier of the PRC Wang Yang stated that for China the issue of climate change remains of great concern[26].Also, it is highlighted that China is open for further participation in establishing international institutions designed for managing the climate change issue in the Arctic region[27].

Therefore, the study proceeds with a more detailed analysis of each direction of CCP representatives' discourse on Arctic affairs within the period of 2013-2017.

2.2.1. China as a responsible great power (“负责任大国” [28])

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[22] “Statement by Minister Wang Yi at the Opening Ceremony of the Third Circumpolar Forum Assembly” The State Council of the People’s Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/guowuyuan/vom/2015-10/19/content_2950053.htm [王毅部长在第三届北极圈论坛大会开幕式上的致辞]

[23] Ibid.

[24] “Keynote address by Vice-Minister for Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming at the China country-specific session of the Third Circumpolar Forum General Assembly” Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People’s Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201510/t20151017_7945486.shtml [外交部副部长张明在“第三届北极圈论坛大会”中国国别专题会议上的主旨发言]

[25] Ibid.

[26] “Wang Yang Attends 4th International Arctic Forum” Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People’s Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/zyxw/201703/t20170330_340778.shtml [汪洋出席第四届国际北极论坛]

[27] Ibid.

[28] “Deputy Director General of the State Oceanic Administration explains the Regulations on the Administration of Administrative Licences for Arctic Expedition Activities ”The State Council of the People’s Republic of China,

As in 2013 China became an observer state in the Arctic Council, the PRC became more engaged in Arctic affairs, thus leaving China the possibility to actively spread the notion of China being a trustful actor in the region with huge material capabilities. Thus, in Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs a new concept of China being a 'responsible great power' ('负责任大国')[29] started to appear. Chinese officials claim that China is ready for a more active role in the Arctic region as China is already integrated into major mechanisms of Arctic governance, including the Svalbard treaty and the Arctic Council, as well as China is open for further cooperation with the international community to explore the region, develop its territories and protect its fragile ecosystem[30]. Moreover, the increased efforts of China in the Arctic region are beneficial for humankind, as the issue of ice melting in the Arctic is the litmus test for the global community to understand which environmental challenges to expect in the future[31]. Therefore, the involvement of China in Arctic Affairs is perceived by the CCP representatives as an opportunity to contribute to the exploration of the region in order to develop the Arctic deeper and more comprehensively, which is in the interests of the whole global community.

However, it is also implied that as a responsible power China not only has to protect the region, but also to safeguard its national interests in the Arctic and promote international cooperation[32]. Therefore, for the representatives of the CCP, responsibility in the Arctic region implies responsibility towards the region and its stability and development and responsibility towards Chinese national interests which have to be protected by the PRC.

Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from :https://www.gov.cn/zhengce/2017-09/20/content_5226465.htm [国家海洋局副局长解读《北极考察活动行政许可管理规定》]

[29] Ibid.

[30] Ibid.

[31] "State Oceanic Administration: frequency of China's Arctic scientific research increased to once a year" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2017-10/10/content_5230819.htm [国家海洋局：我国北极科考频次增至每年一次]

[32] "Deputy Director General of the State Oceanic Administration explains the Regulations on the Administration of Administrative Licences for Arctic Expedition Activities" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/zhengce/2017-09/20/content_5226465.htm [国家海洋局副局长解读《北极考察活动行政许可管理规定》]

2.2.2. China as an Arctic stakeholder

By 2017 the idea of China being "Near-Arctic state" shifted to the concept of "Arctic stakeholder"("利益攸关方") [33], which has a broader meaning, making emphasis not only on the geographical position of China which could be questioned by the Arctic states, but on capabilities of the PRC to be an influential actor in the region[34].

Such a concept leaves for China more opportunities to justify its presence in the Arctic region. Therefore, in the discourse of Chinese officials the concept of 'Arctic stakeholder' is used to highlight that China has already achieved success in scientific and environmental projects in the region and aims to deepen the development of the region by increasing its efforts and cooperating more with other states[35].

The concept of 'Arctic stakeholder' was also developed by the CCP party members, as in 2017 it was outlined that the 'Arctic stakeholder' consists of 3 more characteristics of Chinese involvement in the Arctic region, as the PRC is also a 'participant' ('参与者'), a 'constructor' ('建设者') and a 'contributor' ('贡献者') in the Arctic affairs, which has both willingness and ability to take a larger role in the development of the Arctic region[36].

2.2.3. Respect, collaboration and win-win cooperation ("尊重、合作与共赢")

The principles of respect, collaboration and win-win cooperation are main concepts in the Arctic policy of China, which the PRC adhere to[37]. The concept of "respect" ("尊重") implies that China respects the jurisdiction of Arctic states on

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[33] Ibid.
[34] Ibid.
[35] Ibid.
[36] "Wang Yang Attends 4th International Arctic Forum" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/zyxw/201703/t20170330_340778.shtml [汪洋出席第四届国际北极论坛]
[37] "Statement by Minister Wang Yi at the Opening Ceremony of the Third Circumpolar Forum Assembly" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/guowuyuan/vom/2015-10/19/content_2950053.htm [王毅部长在第三届北极圈论坛大会开幕式上的致辞]

their territory and the sovereignty of their Arctic territories, as well as the interests and rights of all parties involved, including Non-Arctic states, indigenous population of the region and international community[38]. "Cooperation" ("合作") denotes as the main type of Chinese activity in the Arctic region, as the PRC tends to cooperate with Arctic states in order to promote its projects on the territory of Arctics[39]. What is more, China is ready to cooperate not only with Arctic states, but also with Non-Arctic ones and other interested parties in any field of cooperation, including shipping, resource extraction, climate change, environmental protection and sustainable development[40]. The third concept is the 'win-win cooperation' ('共赢') which reflects one of the main goals of Chinese participation in Arctic affairs, as China considers Arctic as a region which should be safe, sustainable and peaceful, which would benefit everyone, whereas negative drawback of violent behavior or environmental change are also harmful for everyone[41]. Therefore, the PRC calls for cooperation in the Arctic region to achieve mutually beneficial goals.

However, in 2017 two concepts of collaboration and win-win cooperation were merged into one principle of collaboration, whereas the new concept of sustainability (可持续) emerged[42]. Within the CCP discourse the principle of sustainability is about the necessity to find a balance between the development and protection of the Arctic region, as it is essential for the achievement of the long-term goals of the Arctic development[43]. What is more, such balance is crucial for preservation of the environmental state of the region to attain peaceful coexistence between man and nature.

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[38] Ibid.
[39] Ibid.
[40] Ibid.
[41] Ibid.
[42] "International Arctic Forum for Cooperative Development Concludes in Russia" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2017-03/31/content_5182371.htm [力主合作开发的国际北极论坛在俄闭幕]
[43] "Wang Yang: China's Participation in Arctic Affairs Based on Three Policy Concepts of Respect, Cooperation and Sustainability" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/zyxw/201703/t20170329_340758.shtml [汪洋：中国秉承尊重、合作、可持续三大政策理念参与北极事务]

2.2.4. Chinese cooperation within the Arctic region

The role of Arctic states, Near-Arctic states and the whole international system in Arctic affairs is an important part of the Chinese discourse on the Arctic region within the period of 2013-2017. In 2015 when the Vice-Minister of Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming outlined 6 main political concepts of Chinese actions in the Arctic region, where the four of them were dedicated to the attitude of China towards international cooperation[44].The first concept highlights the necessity for "respect for the inalienable rights of Arctic States and Arctic Indigenous Peoples" ("尊重北极国家和北极土著人的固有权利"), which implies that China recognizes the sovereignty of the Arctic states and the rights and interests of indigenous people[45]. The next concept is about the "respect for the rights of extraterritorial Arctic states and the general interests of the international community" ("尊重北极域外国家的权利和国际社会的整体利益"), claiming that the international law granted extraterritorial states with the right to hold researches and navigation on the territory of the Arctic region[46]. Therefore, Chinese representatives of the CCP consider that such rights to be participate in Arctic affairs should be protected by the international community in order to secure the region and maintain the current pace of development[47]. The third concept promotes "the creation of a multi-level win-win structure for the cooperation in the Arctic region" ("构建以共赢为目标的多层次北极合作框架")[48]. The Chinese politicians speak about the fact that the Arctic region is crucial for the survival and development of mankind and therefore all states in the international community should cooperate within the Arctic region, creating a three-layer-system for communication on the national, regional and global levels[49].

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[44] "Keynote address by Vice-Minister for Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming at the China country-specific session of the Third Circumpolar Forum General Assembly" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201510/t20151017_7945486.shtml [外交部副部长张明在"第三届北极圈论坛大会"中国国别专题会议上的主旨发言]
[45] Ibid.
[46] Ibid.
[47] Ibid.
[48] Ibid.
[49] Ibid.

During this time period the trilateral Arctic dialogue between China, Japan and South Korea started, confirming the fact that Chinese discourse is aligned with the Chinese Arctic policy[50]. The last concept on the Arctic cooperation outlines "the necessity to maintain the system of Arctic governance based on existing international law" ("维护以现有国际法为基础的北极治理体系"), as China considers the UN Charter, UNCLOS and the Svalbard treaty as a legal base for Arctic management, claiming that the system is sufficient enough to preserve it[51]. Thus, in the field of Arctic cooperation the PRC stands for global cooperation in various directions of Arctic affairs to maintain the stability and security in the region based on already existing mechanisms of governance.

2.3. Community of Common Destiny for Mankind

As the period of 2013-2017 started with President Xi coming to power, the general directions of Chinese foreign policy during that period also underwent significant changes. Therefore, some directions of foreign policy of China were interconnected due to the similarities in the discourse and decision-making process. The political concept of the "Community of Common Destiny for mankind" ("人类命运共同体") was promoted by Xi Jinping to foster global cooperation in international relations, as nowadays many challenges are global and therefore, they require global address[52]. The idea of the community with a shared future coincides with a trend on the joint Arctic development, which China promoted as a benefit for the global international community. Thus, the representatives of CCP in their speeches referred to the fact that the climate changes in the Arctic region that

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[50] "Joint Statement of the Second Round of the China-Japan-Korea High-level Dialogue on Arctic Affairs" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/wjbxw_673019/201706/t20170614_384812.shtml [第二轮中日韩北极事务高级别对话联合声明]

[51] "Keynote address by Vice-Minister for Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming at the China country-specific session of the Third Circumpolar Forum General Assembly" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201510/t20151017_7945486.shtml [外交部副部长张明在"第三届北极圈论坛大会"中国国别专题会议上的主旨发言]

[52] "Advocating and forging a community of human destiny - A review of diplomacy since the 18th National Congress" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 17, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/jrzg/2013-12/15/content_2548061.htm [倡导和打造人类命运共同体—十八大以来外交述评]

happened in recent years not only affect the climate in other states but also affect their economic development, as it has direct influence in production, agriculture and the possibility of prevention of probable disasters, making the Arctic region one of the main factors in further global development[53]. Moreover, the concept of China being a "responsible great power" ("负责任大国") can contribute to more comprehensive understanding and exploration of the Arctic region[54], which benefit to the whole international society also correspond with the community with a shared future, which imply joint communication and management of issues, which are crucial for the international community. Another important issue that the representatives of the CCP refer to is globalization, as due to the process of globalization such issues as the development and security of the Arctic region as well as the problem of climate change are becoming important to everyone, making international cooperation the best outcome[55]. The concept of "win-win cooperation" ("共赢") on the territory of the Arctic region could also be considered as a part of a discourse on Community of Common Destiny for Mankind, as the idea that for the international society it is more beneficial to preserve safe and stable Arctic, as its further development is in the interest for mankind[56]. Therefore, it could be concluded that the idea of the Arctic region being a common territory proclaimed by many CCP representatives could be considered as a continuation of the concept of 'Community of Common Destiny for Mankind'.

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[53] "Deputy Director General of the State Oceanic Administration explains the Regulations on the Administration of Administrative Licences for Arctic Expedition Activities" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 17, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/zhengce/2017-09/20/content_5226465.htm [国家海洋局副局长解读《北极考察活动行政许可管理规定》]

[54] "State Oceanic Administration: frequency of China's Arctic scientific research increased to once a year" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2017-10/10/content_5230819.htm [国家海洋局：我国北极科考频次增至每年一次]

[55] "Keynote address by Vice-Minister for Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming at the China country-specific session of the Third Circumpolar Forum General Assembly" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201510/t20151017_7945486.shtml [外交部副部长张明在"第三届北极圈论坛大会"中国国别专题会议上的主旨发言]

[56] "Statement by Minister Wang Yi at the Opening Ceremony of the Third Circumpolar Forum Assembly" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/guowuyuan/vom/2015-10/19/content_2950053.htm [王毅部长在第三届北极圈论坛大会开幕式上的致辞]

2.4. Environmental protection and climate change

For representatives of the CCP the issue of preservation of the Arctic environment is crucial for the security of China, as negative drawbacks of the ecological situation in the Arctic would eventually impact the stability and security in the PRC. Therefore, two of Chinese political concepts on its activities in the Arctic region, which were proclaimed in 2015 are dedicated to the environmental aspect of the Arctics[57]**.** The first concept is about "the necessity to advance Arctic research and knowledge" ("推进探索和认知北极"), claiming that the Arctic region is an experimental zone for all research expedition and the region where climate change is most visible, therefore the CCP politicians promote the idea to create a common base for the utilization and protection of the Arctic region, which would benefit for all the states[58]. Another concept advocates for "the protection and sustainable use of the Arctic and promotion of Arctic research and knowledge" ("倡导保护与合理利用北极推进探索和认知北极")[59], as despite the fact that the Arctic region has a large amount of resources and maritime routes essential for shipping, its ecosystem requires considerable protection from the international society. Therefore, the CCP policymakers stand for a balanced attitude towards rational utilization of the region and its protection[60].

In 2017 the attitude of China towards the ecological agenda became an even more important part of the Arctic discourse, as the Vice Premier of the PRC Wang Yang claimed that ecology protection should be a priority for China and other states[61], and thus China is ready to increase its participation in every direction of its activities in the region, as well as to take part in the development of institutional

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[57] "Keynote address by Vice-Minister for Foreign Affairs Zhang Ming at the China country-specific session of the Third Circumpolar Forum General Assembly" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201510/t20151017_7945486.shtml [外交部副部长张明在"第三届北极圈论坛大会"中国国别专题会议上的主旨发言]

[58] Ibid.

[59] Ibid.

[60] Ibid.

[61] "Wang Yang: Working together to create a bright new future for the Arctic" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/zyxw/201703/t20170329_340761.shtml [汪洋：共同开创北极美好新未来]

mechanisms of Arctic governance, as China stands for ‘peaceful utilization of the Arctic region’ (‘和平利用北极’)[62].

2.5. Chapter conclusion

In conclusion, the analysis of the Chinese Communist Party representatives discourse on Arctic affairs within the period of 2013-2017 has revealed that China maintained its adherence to main principles of its activities in the region, such as its adherence to international law, agreements between states and recognition of sovereign rights of Arctic states on their territory. Moreover, the concept of ‘Near-Arctic state’ which was used before the period of 2013-2017 has evolved into the notion of the PRC as an ‘Arctic stakeholder’, giving China more opportunities to justify and increase its participation in Arctic affairs.

After president Xi came to power his administration has shifted to more active promotion of joint usage of the Arctic region based on the principles of cooperation, respect and achievement of win-win outcomes for all actors in the international community. The Chinese discourse on the Arctic region is also aligned with the conception of Community of Common Destiny for Mankind, thus framing Arctic activities as mutually beneficial maintenance of peace and stability in the Arctic together with development of the region. Another important issue within the Arctic discourse of China is protection of the Arctic environment which should be implemented by all actors in the international community, as climate change in the Arctic region directly affects the stability and development of other regions of the world. The concept of China as a ‘responsible great power’ which emerged during that period also shows how China started to use its position in the region and financial capabilities as a legitimization and explanation of the necessity to be an Arctic player. The discourse of CCP representatives also shifted from bilateral projects with Arctic states to the growing importance of multi-layer cooperation both with Arctic states and Non-Arctic ones, thus promoting more inclusive form of Arctic governance, which would provide China with more opportunities to fulfill its interests in the region which include the development of

[62] Ibid.

maritime routes and resource exploration and extraction. Therefore, within the period of 2013-2017 the discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs became more diversified, shifting to new areas of cooperation and aiming to assert its position in the region.

Chapter 3 The Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs within the period of 2018-2024

Introduction

Chapter 3 provides the analysis of the discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs within the period of 2018-2024 based on statements, speeches and interviews published by the Government of China, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Xinhua News Agency. This study outlines major aspects of Chinese Arctic policy which are compliance with previous Arctic policies, changes in the discourse within the administration of president Xi, the creation of White paper on the Arctic region, the promotion of the Belt and Road initiative, and the issue of security.

3.1. Compliance with direction of the discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs before 2013

This part of the chapter analyses the compliance of the discourse within the period of 2018-1014 with main directions of the discourse before 2013 and within the period of 2013-2017. Similar to chapter 2, chapter 3 studies the presence of such aspects as Chinese adherence to international norms and participation in international organizations, its support of sovereignty and interests of the Arctic state and the concept of 'Near-Arctic state' in the discourse of CCP representatives.

3.1.1. China as a good party to international treaties and organizations

During 2018-2024 the PRC continued to create the vision of China as a faithful party of international treaties and organizations, to maintain and increase the perception of the PRC as an Arctic player. Thus, Chinese politicians claim that faithful cooperation with all interested parties is an effective way of communication within the Arctic discourse[63], putting emphasis on the maintenance of China-Nordic Arctic Cooperation Seminars (中国北欧北极合作研讨会)[64] to highlight the level of cooperation with Arctic states and mentioning Congress of

[63] "Vice Foreign Minister Kong Xuanyou attends the press conference on 'China's Arctic Policy' and answers reporters' questions." Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201801/t20180126_9870161.shtml [外交部副部长孔铉佑出席《中国的北极政策》白皮书新闻发布会并回答记者提问实录]

[64] Ibid.

the World's Reindeer Breeders (世界驯鹿养殖者代表大会)[65] to show good relations between China and indigenous Arctic population.

Still, in 2018-2024 the discourse of CCP representatives faced a shift towards bilateral cooperation with the Arctic states, especially with Russia. Establishment of bilateral agreements and joint projects, such as "Yamal LNG" (亚马尔 LNG) are used as good examples of cooperation in the Arctic region by Chinese politicians[66].

Moreover, the idea of the creation of multilayer system of Arctic governance, which consists of national, regional and global layers, which was discussed in chapter 2 was continued by Chinese politicians, as they proceed with referring to the trilateral dialogue between China, South Korea and Japan[67], considering it as a good example of regional dialogue on Arctic affairs, which is effective in enhancing the level of cooperation between 3 states[68]. Also, in the sphere of environmental protection, China continued to adhere to international treaties, thus, not only claiming that environmental issue remains an important part of Chinese Arctic policy, but also put an emphasis on the fact that Chinese principles of adherence to international law remain relevant for the state. Hence, the CCP policymakers claim that the PRC follows the principles of the Paris Agreement to preserve the Arctic ecosystem and conservative its species[69]. Thus, the representatives of the Chinese Communist Party still highlight that China is an important and trustful partner within the framework of Arctic governance.

3.1.2. China as a supporter of preserving the sovereignty and interests of Arctic states

The emphasis on the recognition of the interests of the Arctic states and the sovereignty of their Arctic territories remains an important aspect of Chinese discourse. The chapter 2 of this study provided the information that as in 2013-2017 China started to broaden this concept, by outlining that the PRC also respects

[65] Ibid.
[66] Ibid.
[67] Ibid.
[68] Ibid.
[69] Ibid.

the interests of indigenous Arctic population, non-Arctic states and other interested parties and China is open for further cooperation. Therefore, during the period of 2018-2024 the CCP representatives continued to proclaim that China supports and respects the rights of all the parties involved in Arctic affairs, as in 2018 the Chinese politicians highlighted that China still adheres to the principles of Arctic security and cooperation in the Arctic region[70]. The issue of Arctic security implies that the PRC aims to strengthen the protection of the Arctic region in different spheres, including climate change, protection of natural environment, as well as the CCP representatives highlight that the PRC respects culture, interests and rights of the indigenous population of the Arctic region[71]. The cooperation covers the necessity to continue and enhance the level of cooperation with all parties involved on the mutually beneficial basis[72]. Therefore, the positioning of China as a state which respects the rights and interests of its counterparts remains an important aspect of its Arctic discourse in the period of 2018-2024.

3.1.3. China as a Near-Arctic state

Within the period of 2018-2024 the PRC has shifted from the concept of 'Near-Arctic state' ('近北极国家') to the idea of China being 'Arctic stakeholder' ('利益攸关方'), which provides more comprehensive definition of Chinese abilities in the region. Thus, one of the last mentionings of the concept of 'Near-Arctic state' was in 2018, when the right of China to participate in the Arctica affairs was, among other things, explained by its geographical position[73].

3.2. Chinese White Paper on the Arctic

In 2018 the PRC published its first White Paper on the Arctic region, which became the first official guideline for Chinese Arctic policy[74]. Therefore, the White Paper is an important part of CCP representatives' discourse on the Arctic region. It

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[70] Ibid.
[71] Ibid.
[72] Ibid.
[73] Ibid.
[74] "The Ministry of Foreign Affairs issued a statement on the State New Office "China's Arctic Policy" White Paper and other questions and answers" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 18, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2018-01/26/content_5261152.htm [外交部就国新办发表《中国的北极政策》白皮书等答问]

was stated, that the publication of such document in 2018 is not a coincidence, as since 1990s the PRC was gradually deepening its integration into the system of Arctic governance and therefore, by 2018 China accumulated enough knowledge and power to clarify and generalize its Arctic policies, as other Non-Arctic states like the UK, Japan and South Korea already did[75]. Thus, the official representative of Chinese MFA uses the idiom '水到渠成' to outline, that 2018 was the best time for China to take more active position in the Arctic region[76].

Through the discourse on the White Paper on the Arctic region, the CCP representatives start to highlight that the PRC is the 'Arctic stakeholder' ('北极事务的重要利益攸关方'), shifting from the concept of 'Near-Arctic state' ('近北极国') in the official discourse[77]. Moreover, the Chinese politicians started to refer to 4 main principles of Chinese decision-making in the Arctic region, which are: 'clear position' ('明确定位'), 'explanation of propositions' ('阐释主张'), 'goals setting' ('设定目标'), 'principles adherence' ('坚持原则')[78].

Thus, 'clear positioning' implies that the PRC positions itself as the 'Arctic stakeholder' and this identity perceived by China reflects its Arctic policies[79]. The principle of 'explanation of propositions' implies that China has 5 main political suggestions on further Arctic management which affect its behavior in the region[80]. These suggestions are: "First, continuously deepen the exploration and awareness of the Arctic; second, protect the Arctic ecological environment and respond to climate change; third, rationally use Arctic resources in accordance with the law; fourth, actively participate in Arctic governance and international cooperation; fifth, promote Arctic peace and stability"[81]. The next principle of 'goals setting'

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[75] Ibid.
[76] Ibid.
[77] "Vice Minister of Foreign Affairs Kong Xuanyou attended the press conference of the White Paper "China's Arctic Policy" Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 18, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/wjbxw_673019/201801/t20180126_386029.shtml [外交部副部长孔铉佑出席《中国的北极政策》白皮书新闻发布会]
[78] Ibid.
[79] Ibid.
[80] Ibid.
[81] Ibid.

denotes main directions of Chinese Arctic policies, which aimed “to understand the Arctic, to protect the Arctic, to use the Arctic and to participate in the Arctic management”[82]. The last principle is about ‘adherence to the principles’ of ‘respect’ (‘尊重’ [83]), ‘collaboration’ (‘合作’ [84]), ‘win-win cooperation’ ('共赢' [85]) and ‘sustainability’ ('可持续' [86]). Hence, during the period of 2018-2024 the representatives of Chinese Communist Party highlighted that the principle of ‘respect’ ('尊重') represents the respect of rights and interests of all parties involved in Arctic affairs[87]. The principle of ‘collaboration’ ('合作') implies the ambitions to establish comprehensive relations with Arctic players on a multiple scale[88]. The ‘win-win cooperation’ ('共赢') implies the aim to establish mutually beneficial relations between all interested parties striving for harmony in all the directions of Arctic activities[89]. The principle of ‘sustainability’ ('可持续') denotes environmental protection assistance and sustainable use of resources and development of the Arctic region[90]. Therefore, the fact that in 2018 the CCP representatives use four principles instead of merging collaboration and win-win cooperation into one, as it was discussed in chapter 2, marks the change in the CCP Arctic discourse.

3.3. The Belt and Road initiative

The Belt and Road initiative (一带一路) became an important part of the CCP representatives’ discourse on Arctic affairs. As the initiative proved its efficiency, Chinese politicians started to consider it as one of the most effective systems to improve global governance and create a new model of international cooperation[91]. Thus, this part of the chapter 3 analyzes the discourse of CCP

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[82] Ibid.
[83] Ibid.
[84] Ibid.
[85] Ibid.
[86] Ibid.
[87] Ibid.
[88] Ibid.
[89] Ibid.
[90] Ibid.
[91] “The Ministry of Foreign Affairs issued a statement on the State New Office "China's Arctic Policy" White Paper and other questions and answers” The State Council of the People’s Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025

representatives on the issue of developing BRI initiative in the Arctic region, covering aspects of the cooperation between Russia and China and the establishment of the Polar Silk Road (冰上丝绸之路).

3.3.1. China-Russia cooperation

The cooperation between China and Russia in the Arctic region remains an important aspect of Chinese Arctic policy and the development of the BRI initiative. The representatives of the Chinese Communist Party consider Russia as a great Arctic power (北极大国) which has a great influence on the process of Arctic management[92]. Thus, the PRC representatives often refer to the successful long-term cooperation between the two states in the Arctic region, highlighting that the PRC is ready to deepen the multidimensional cooperation with Russia on the basis of Sino-Russian Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (中俄全面战略合作伙伴关系)[93]. Moreover, the representatives of the CCP often refer to such issues as climate change and ice melting to highlight the importance of the Arctic sea Routes in international trade and transportation[94]. Thus, the PRC representatives claim that China is willing to assist Arctic states in the development of their sea ports, infrastructure and maritime science, on condition that the Arctic states would govern their Arctic territories based on the international law, thus guaranteeing to other Arctic players like China the right to use and pass through their Arctic sea routes[95]. Also, Li Keqiang claimed that further development of the BRI initiative is deeply connected with Sino-Russian relations, as Russia and the Eurasian Economic Union are considered as main actors in further development of the Belt

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Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2018-01/26/content_5261152.htm [外交部就国新办发表《中国的北极政策》白皮书等答问]

[92] "Vice Foreign Minister Kong Xuanyou attends the press conference on 'China's Arctic Policy' and answers reporters' questions." Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201801/t20180126_9870161.shtml [外交部副部长孔铉佑出席《中国的北极政策》白皮书新闻发布会并回答记者提问实录]

[93] Ibid.

[94] Ibid.

[95] Ibid.

and Road Initiative[96]. Therefore, further cooperation with Russia is essential for China for further development of the Arctic model of BRI.

By 2024 the process of deepening the cooperation in the Arctic region started and in 2024 China and Russia established "Arctic Express No. 1" logistics train to connect the Russian port of Arkhangelsk and Chinese ports, thus significantly reducing the time expenditure and transportation cost[97]. The Chinese Ambassador to Russia Zhang Hanhui noted that such transportation improvement would benefit not only to the fields of transportation and logistics but also to all other types of Comprehensive Strategic Partnership including trade, investments and technological innovations[98].

3.3.2. Polar Silk Road

The growing influence of China in the Arctic region allowed the PRC to start more active promotion of the Belt and Road initiative. Thus, the CCP policymakers claim, that the proximity to the Arctic circle does not limit state's ability to participate in the Arctic affairs[99], and as the PRC is already the Arctic stakeholder with a history of involvement in the Arctic governance, China aims to 'bring Chinese wisdom and strength to the sustainable development of the Arctic region'[100]. Therefore, together with Arctic states, China aims to create 'Polar Silk Road' ('冰上丝绸之路') which would operate for the benefit of the common future and sustainable development of the Arctic region[101].

The name of the 'Polar Silk Road' also undergone some changes within recent years, as in 2017 President Xi used the name 'Polar Silk Road'('冰上丝绸

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[96] "Li Keqiang's written interview with Russia's TASS news agency (full text)"The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/guowuyuan/2019-09/16/content_5430056.htm [李克强接受俄罗斯塔斯社书面采访（全文)]

[97] "The first 'Arctic Express 1' logistics train started in Russia" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from:https://www.gov.cn/yaowen/liebiao/202407/content_6961713.htm [首列"北极快线 1 号"物流专列在俄开行]

[98] Ibid.

[99] "China Sub-Forum of the Arctic Circle Forum held in Shanghai" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2019-05/14/content_5391336.htm [北极圈论坛中国分论坛在上海举行]

[100] Ibid.

[101] Ibid.

之路’)[102] whereas in the official White Paper on the Arctic policy the name of ‘Silk Road in the Arctic’ (‘北极的“丝绸之路”’) was used[103]. However, the Vice Foreign Minister Kong Xuanyou explained that BRI is a general programme that China conducts on the territory of various regions, being ready to cooperate with any state, whereas ‘Polar Silk Road’ is a part of the general Belt and Road Initiative, conducted by China and Russia aimed for the development and utilization of Arctic sea routes[104]. Therefore, within the period of 2018-2024 the promotion and development of ‘Polar Silk Road’ was an important part of Chinese discourse on the Arctic affair, as further integration of ‘Polar Silk Road’ into BRI and its development would allow China to increase its presence in the Arctic region, improve the relations with Arctic states by holding joint projects to improve the infrastructure of their Arctic territories and increase trade volume through new transportation routes.

3.4. Perception of Arctic policies by president Xi administration

This study proceeds with an overview of main features of the discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs within the period of 2018-2024, which are depicted on the figure 2.

Discourse topic	**Year**	**Author**	**Main features**
Principles of ‘not to go overboard and not to be absent’	2018	Kong Xuanyou, Vice Foreign Minister of the PRC	1. China is a non-aggressive state, with no ambitions to take dominant position in the region 2. China is ready to cooperate on the basis of international law

[102] “Vice Foreign Minister Kong Xuanyou attends the press conference on ‘China's Arctic Policy’ and answers reporters' questions.” Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People’s Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201801/t20180126_9870161.shtml [外交部副部长孔铉佑出席《中国的北极政策》白皮书新闻发布会并回答记者提问实录]
[103] Ibid.
[104] Ibid.

			3. China is not interested in interfering in domestic affairs of Arctic state or in inter- state conflicts in the Arctic 4. China is an 'Arctic stakeholder' which has to be presented in the region
Protection of the Arctic governance system	2018	Kong Xuanyou, Vice Foreign Minister of the PRC	1. China stands for protection of Arctic governance system based on international law and legal treaties
Respect of the Arctic governance system	2018	Kong Xuanyou, Vice Foreign Minister of the PRC	1. China stands for respect of already existing mechanisms of Arctic governance
Development of the Arctic governance system	2018	Kong Xuanyou, Vice Foreign Minister of the PRC	1. China supports the development of Arctic governance system with demands of times
Securitization of the Arctic region	2018	Kong Xuanyou, Vice Foreign Minister of the PRC	1. China is not an aggressor and does not have hidden ambitions in the region 2. China calls for all states to comply with international law in order to

			preserve Arctic ecosystem and population 3. China is a powerful state, capable of participation in Arctic affairs and coordinating other states 4. Unlike the US, which withdrew from Paris Agreement, China aims to preserve Arctic ecosystem.

Therefore, within the period of 2018-2024 the principle of 'not going overboard and not being absent'[105]proclaimed by the Vice Foreign Minister of the PRC Kong Xuanyou implies that China does not aim to interfere in domestic affairs of Arctic states and does not have intentions to take the dominant position in the region. On the contrary, China is ready for cooperation with all interested parties on the basis of international law, and as an 'Arctic stakeholder' has its own interests and responsibilities in the region[106]. What is more, the idea of the Arctic governance system protection is about the fact that China supports the existing mechanisms of Arctic governance which are based on international law and legal treaties and aims to preserve this system[107]. What is more, the respect of Arctic governance system implies the support and respect towards existing mechanisms of governance[108]. Therefore, the CCP representatives stand for the idea of further development of such mechanism in order to adjust them to the modern politics[109]. Another important point in CCP representatives' discourse on Arctic affairs is the

[105] "Foreign Ministry responds to U.S. accusation of China's participation in Arctic affairs: China does not overstep its bounds, does not lack position" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2019-05/07/content_5389492.htm [外交部回应美方指责中国参与北极事务：中方不越位、不缺位]
[106] Ibid.
[107] Ibid.
[108] Ibid.
[109] Ibid.

issue of securitization in the region, as the Chinese representative claimed that China has no hidden ambitions and clearly positions its goals in the region, stressing that its actions always comply with international law. Thus, addressing accusations from the US officials, the Vice Foreign Minister of the PRC Kong Xuanyou stressed that China is a supporter of international treaties such as the Paris Agreement and thus China faithfully adheres to its principles unlike states like the US who withdrew from the treaty[110]. Moreover, CCP representatives stated that China has enough power and capabilities to be presented in the region and participate in its affairs, thus promoting regional development and reservation of its ecosystem[111].

Therefore, the study proceeds with a more detailed analysis of each direction of CCP representatives' discourse on Arctic affairs within the period of 2018-2024.

3.4.1. Principles of 'not to go overboard and not to be absent'('不越位、不缺位'[112])

During the period of 2018-2024 the Chinese government aimed to continue already existing policies of deepening its presence in the Arctic region. Therefore, in 2018 the Vice Foreign Minister Kong Xuanyou outlined that the PRC positions itself as a 'significant Arctic stakeholder' ('重要利益攸关方'[113]) which adhere to the two main principles of its presence in the Arctic region, where the first one is 'not to go overboard' ('不越位'[114]) and the second one is 'not to be absent'('不缺位'[115]). Using the first principle, the PRC representatives highlight, that China is not interested in affairs that happen only between Arctic states and affect only their interests, as well as China does not have any intentions of taking the dominant

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[110] Ibid.
[111] Ibid.
[112] Ibid.
[113] "Vice Foreign Minister Kong Xuanyou attends the press conference on 'China's Arctic Policy' and answers reporters' questions." Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201801/t20180126_9870161.shtml [外交部副部长孔铉佑出席《中国的北极政策》白皮书新闻发布会并回答记者提问实录]
[114] Ibid.
[115] Ibid.

position in the region[116]. Therefore, such a principle could underline the willingness of China to operate on the basis of international law and an already established institutional framework. The second principle of being non-absent in the region could be considered as an attempt of China to claim their right on participating in arctic affairs, based on their perception of the PRC as the 'Arctic stakeholder' with geographical proximity to the region and global and national interests in the region[117]. Hence, the CCP representatives' discourse on Arctic affairs is shaped around the idea of representing rights and interests of the PRC in the region, including their bilateral projects with Arctic states, interests in logistics and transportation as well as scientific research.

The necessity of China to promote the vision of the PRC as a non-aggressive Arctic player is one of the most important aspects of the discourse on Arctic affairs within the given period, as China has to prove its non-aggressive behaviour to other Arctic states in order to proceed with already existing policies and project and to deepen the level of participation in regional affairs. As the US remains the state with most suspicious attitude towards Chinese desire to gain control of the region, the PRC has to react to such accusations, thus not only to maintain relations with the US, but also to keep the relations with European states, such as Finland, Norway and the Denmark which policies are directly affected by their relations with the US, as it was described in chapter 1. Therefore, in response to the American criticism on Chinese unclear ambitions in the Arctic region, the Foreign Ministry spokesman Geng Shuang noted that China is interested in trans-regional and global issues only, having no intentions to intervene into bilateral relations between Arctic states[118]. Moreover, the representative marked the increasing trend of China to participate in activities dedicated to the issues of peace and cooperation in the region, not in geopolitical rivalry between Arctic states[119]. Thus, the idea of

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[116] Ibid.
[117] Ibid.
[118] "Foreign Ministry responds to U.S. accusation of China's participation in Arctic affairs: China does not overstep its bounds, does not lack position" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2019-05/07/content_5389492.htm [外交部回应美方指责中国参与北极事务：中方不越位、不缺位]
[119] Ibid.

possible threats and opportunities that emerge in the Arctic and are important to the global community is still used in the Arctic discourse of the CCP representatives to show peaceful identity of the Chinese policies in the Arctic region, which aimed at achieving mutually beneficial outcomes.

3.4.2. Chinese position on Arctic governance

Within the period of 2018-2024 China aimed to engage in the process of Arctic governance in order to be perceived as an 'Arctic stakeholder' and promote Chinese vision of the Arctic governance. Therefore, in 2018 the CCP representatives outlined 3 main directions of Arctic governance, which are most important for China[120] These directions are 'protection' ('维护'[121]), 'respect' ('尊重'[122]) and 'development' ('发展'[123]). The 'protection' implies protection of already existing legal basis for Arctic governance, including the adherence to the Svalbard treaty, UNCLOS and UN Charter[124]. Hence, the CCP representatives consider that the legal framework of Arctic governance is efficient enough to be maintained and protected by the Chinese side. The idea of 'respect' is about the respect for already existing mechanisms of Arctic governance, including international organizations on the regional, national and global levels, as such mechanisms provide a platform for mutual respect among Arctic players and create possibilities for further cooperation[125]. Thus, for China, any further direction of Arctic governance development should take into account existing mechanisms of its governance in order to preserve the instruments which allow inclusive participation of all the actors. By the concept of 'development' the CCP representatives mean further development of the system of Arctic government in line with the demands of the times[126]. Hence, the mechanisms of Arctic governance

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[120] "Vice Foreign Minister Kong Xuanyou attends the press conference on 'China's Arctic Policy' and answers reporters' questions." Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201801/t20180126_9870161.shtml [外交部副部长孔铉佑出席《中国的北极政策》白皮书新闻发布会并回答记者提问实录]
[121] Ibid.
[122] Ibid.
[123] Ibid.
[124] Ibid.
[125] Ibid.
[126] Ibid.

should not remain unchanged but rather be adjusted to any change, making the system less vulnerable in any sphere of activities in the Arctic.

3.5. The issue of securitization within Arctic discourse

The issue of securitization is an important area of the Arctic discourse within recent years. As it was analyzed in chapter 1, Arctic states perceive the Arctic region as a place where the process of securitization could drastically change the existing balance of power. The increasing role of China in the Arctic region allows Arctic states to question its real motives, thus starting to accuse China of having hidden intentions. Still, the PRC in its discourse aims to present its vision of the Arctic order, highlighting the peaceful role of China.

To begin with, China categorises the security of the Arctic itself and its defence as a separate category. Regarding China's policy in the Arctic, Chinese representatives emphasise that China has no ulterior motives to build up its military power, thereby increasing its presence in the region, or to independently utilize resources that belong to the Arctic states[127]. Moreover, in the discourse of the Chinese Communist Party representatives, there is the idea that China does not act as an aggressor in the Arctic region, also stating the fact that Arctic states have a strong and reliable legal system that prevents aggressive behaviour by any other state[128]. Besides, China is always in favour of respecting the existing legal system, so the PRC believes that any company's activities should be conducted in accordance with the domestic jurisdiction of the Arctic country where the activities take place, international law and the domestic laws of the country where the company is registered[129]. The CCP representatives also claim that all actors in the Arctic have their own social obligations, according to which the rights of all those involved in Arctic projects and local populations must be strictly respected[130].

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[127] "Vice Foreign Minister Kong Xuanyou attends the press conference on 'China's Arctic Policy' and answers reporters' questions." Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed April 4, 2025, Retrieved from: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/web/ziliao_674904/zyjh_674906/201801/t20180126_9870161.shtml [外交部副部长孔铉佑出席《中国的北极政策》白皮书新闻发布会并回答记者提问实录]

[128] Ibid.

[129] Ibid.

[130] Ibid.

Another important dimension of security issue is the ecological security of the Arctic, as in the discourse of the CCP representatives the issue of climate change and ecological protection is framed as global problem, which could be managed by the collective actions of all the states, thus making the perception of China as a powerful state, which has responsibility to address global threats and aim to coordinate cooperation between states[131]. Hence, in order to show peaceful nature of Chinese presence in the Arctic region, the CCP representatives claim that China put a lot of efforts in protecting Arctic ecosystem, unlike the US which withdrew from Paris Agreement[132]. This way, the CCP representatives respond to the accusations from the US politicians to highlight that nowadays China is aware of ecological problems and ready for cooperation to improve the situation thus achieving more beneficial outcomes for every state.

3.6. Chapter conclusion

During the period of 2018-2024, the main features of Chinese policy in the Arctic region, such as its perception of sovereignty, state's interests and international law remained in the discourse of CCP representatives, highlighting that such decision-making in the Arctic region could be considered as the founding principles of Chinese Arctic policy under the presidency of Xi Jinping. Still, as the level of Chinese participation in Arctic affairs increased, the discourse around the role of China in the region and the justification of its ambitions changed from the idea of being 'Near-Arctic state' to the concept of the 'Arctic stakeholder', thus providing China with more opportunities for further development of its Arctic strategy. The starting point of the discourse within this period is the publication of the official White Paper on the Arctic, which stressed main goals and principles of Chinese presence in the region to comprehensively participate in different areas of activities in the region, including exploration of the Arctic and its resources, joint

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[131] "Ministry of Foreign Affairs: regrets failure to issue a common declaration at Arctic Council ministerial meeting" The State Council of the People's Republic of China, Accessed April 10, 2025 Retrieved from: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2019-05/08/content_5389818.htm [外交部：对北极理事会部长级会议未能发表共同宣言表示遗憾]

[132] Ibid.

projects with Arctic states aimed to develop the region and achieve mutually beneficial outcomes, protection of the environment, indigenous population and preservation of already existing mechanisms of the Arctic governance. The development of the Belt and Road initiative and the creation of the 'Polar Silk Road' is another important aspect of the Chinese rhetoric on Arctic affairs and its bilateral relations with Arctic states, especially with Russia. References to the 'Polar Silk Road' in the official discourse allowed China to merge it with the BRI initiative, thus increasing the level of importance of the 'Polar Silk Road' within Chinese Foreign policy and highlighting the role of China in the Arctic region as a player with long and consistent history of involvement in Arctic affairs. The growing tension between China and the US on the role of the PRC in the Arctic was also a part of the discourse within the given period, as for the PRC it was essential to show the peaceful nature of its Arctic policies which is supported by previous periods of their involvement in Arctic affairs when CCP representatives did not show any intentions to dominate in the region and due to the founding principles of Chinese behaviour in the region, such as the achievement of win-win outcomes, stress on respect and cooperation in order to sustainably develop the region.

Conclusion

This study analyzed the transformation of the discourse of representatives of the Chinese Communist Party on the Arctic within the period of 2013-2024, studying main directions of the discourse and political priorities of China in the region. This work provides a following list of key outcomes to present the results:

1) Since the involvement of China in Arctic affairs increased in the 1990s, the CCP representatives expressed its commitment to international law and its willingness to work within the already existing system of Arctic governance. Nevertheless, during the period of 2013-2024, in Chinese discourse emerged the call for improvement of governance mechanisms, which should be implemented by the entire international community on the basis of the already existing system.

2) Despite the fact that China remains a supporter of the vision of the Arctic as a territory open for everyone, the CCP representatives' discourse always emphasises that the PRC recognises the exclusive rights and interests of the Arctic countries, as well as the rights of its indigenous people. However, during the period 2013-2024, this vision has changed, as it now goes hand in hand with the idea that CCP representatives also declares the respect of the rights and interests of non-Arctic states and all interested parties in the Arctic, thus showing openness for dialogue and cooperation with any party in the Arctic, thus expanding the list of possible partners.

3) In the period of 2013-2024, China was still in the process of constructing its Arctic identity as it was undergoing significant changes, moving from a 'near-Arctic state', to an 'Arctic stakeholder', which gives more options for its positioning in the region. And in 2018, China began to see itself as an ‘significant Arctic stakeholder’ which should not to overboard thus not seeking to dominate the region, recognising that Arctic countries have their own interests, but also should not be absent, as China has interests in the region, a history of involvement in Arctic affairs and the ability to continue that involvement, thus remaining an Arctic player.

4) After president Xi came to power, the concept of ‘responsible great power’ emerged to emphasise that the PRC is already part of the system of Arctic governance, as well as an influential player in the international system. Thus, China has a responsibility and a moral obligation to protect the Arctic region, which is crucial for the global security and the security of the PRC. Moreover, China also has to increase its presence in the region, as it is a great power which has to present in the Arctic and improve the level of its involvement in Arctic affairs.

5) In the Arctic discourse, the PRC adheres to the principles of ‘respect, cooperation and mutual benefit’, which they refer to as the basis for their actions in the region. Nevertheless, these principles have also undergone significant changes as in 2017 the principles of cooperation and mutual benefit were merged into one, and ‘sustainability’ became the third principle of their Arctic policy. However, in the period of 2018-2024 the principles were modified, as the four principles were divided into separate ones. Therefore, the emphasis on the sustainability and ecological protection and the role of China in achieving these goals points to the increasing importance of these ideas in CPP representatives' Arctic discourse and Chinese Arctic policy.

6) Also during Xi Jinping‘s presidency, the ideas of creation of a multi-level system of Arctic governance, with national, regional and global layers emerged in the Arctic discourse. Thus, throughout the study period CCP representatives highlighted the necessity to establish such a system, referring to the trilateral dialogue between China, Japan and South Korea, using it as an example of the regional platform for cooperation and decision-making on Arctic affairs.

7) Moreover, the Arctic policy of China and its discourse are aligned with the concept of Community of Common Destiny for Mankind, which was also created by the administration of president Xi. The concept implies the increase in the level of cooperation among states for the good of the humankind, as nowadays due to globalization the society faces global challenges such as climate change and ice melting which should be managed by the whole international community, as

the possible drawbacks and benefits are also common. Within its Arctic discourse, the CCP representatives also highlight the importance of the involvement of all actors in the Arctic protection and development, claiming that such cooperation is mutually beneficial. Hence, this study outlines the connection between these two policies during the period of president Xi.

8) Another important direction of Chinese Arctic discourse is the protection of the Arctic ecosystem. Therefore, the CCP representatives outline that the process of development and exploration of the Arctic region, as well as its protection both from ecological threats and human ones should be done by joint forces. Therefore, China stands for the fact that the Arctic must remain a peaceful region, with no military confrontations.

9) In 2018 the Official White Paper on Chinese Arctic Policy was published to finalise the Arctic strategy of China to secure its status as an Arctic stakeholder. By publishing the White Paper the CCP representatives have also shown their openness for further dialogue with Arctic and Non-Arctic states based on the principles of mutually beneficial cooperation, readiness to explore and protect Arctic ecosystem as well as to operate in the region on the basis of international law. The publication of the White Paper also marked the willingness of the PRC to participate in the process of Arctic governance and be involved in the modernization of mechanisms of governance, thus promoting the necessity to maintain the Arctic as a peaceful and stable region.

10) The Belt and Road Initiative also remains an important part of the Chinese discourse on Arctic affairs, as CCP representatives outline, that China is an Arctic stakeholder which has capabilities and obligations to use Chinese experience and competences to develop the Arctic region, being a supporter of the vision of Arctic as a peaceful and developed place. In Chinese discourse it is highlighted that Russia as a state which has large Arctic territories , including Northern Sea Route, which remains an integral part of the Chinese ‘Polar Silk Road’ remains the most important partner in the development of ‘Polar Silk Road’ despite the fact that both states have different approaches to the Arctic

management, where Russia does not share the Chinese vision of the Arctic and Northern Sea Route as a common territory, which is open for everyone. Thus, cooperation with Russia is essential for the PRC to promote the 'Polar Silk Road' on the basis of Sino-Russian Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.

11) During the period of 2018-2024 a new direction emerged within the CCP representatives discourse on Arctic affairs, as it became essential to highlight that China is a non-aggressive state, which is not aimed to dominate in the Arctic region. Taking into account the fact that the US and its allies question the real ambitions of China in the region. Therefore, the CPC representatives emphasise that China does not interfere in the affairs of the Arctic states and is only interested in fighting global threats, as well as in cooperation aimed at achieving mutually beneficial outcomes. The CCP representatives also refer to Chinese integrity in respect to the implementation of the principles of international law, participation in international organisations and documents to show its peaceful identity, besides, making a contrast between the peaceful China that wants to achieve a mutually beneficial and peaceful coexistence in the Arctic and the USA that has withdrawn from the Paris Agreement, thus showing less intentions towards achieving stability and protection in the Arctic region.

Limitations of the study

One of the main limitations of this work is absence of the analysis of the discourse within non-CCP representatives, thus this work does not study the discourse within non-CCP representatives inside China and international responses to Chinese discourse. Moreover, this study lacks quantitative methodology, leaving no opportunity to quantify the frequency of each concept appearing within discourse of CCP representatives on Arctic affairs.

Prospects for further research

This study leaves room for further inclusion of the analysis of responses from the international community to Chinese position on Arctic affairs, thus providing a more comprehensive study of Chinese role within the framework of Arctic governance and Chinese activities in the region.

Another suggestion for further research is the study of the role of other non-Arctic states, such as India and Brazil in the Arctic region, as within recent years these states also started to more actively pursue Arctic policy. The communication between China and other Non-Arctic states could also be a part of further analysis. What is more, it is suggested to analyze the role of international organizations, such as BRICS within the Arctic region, thus providing a more comprehensive study of current trends in Arctic management and the role of China in the region.

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